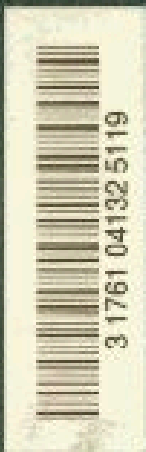




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THE ASCENT OF MAN





THE ASCENT OF MAN



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Transcriber's Notes:

Title punctuation was standardized, but poetry itself retained as in original, including hyphenation variations and indentation changes.

Duplicate title "THE ASCENT OF MAN" at beginning was deleted.

There are two poems titled "THE RED SUNSETS, 1883."; one on P. 154 and the second immediately after it on P. 155.

THE ASCENT OF MAN

BY

MATHILDE BLIND



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THE ASCENT OF MAN.

PRELUDE.

WINGS.

Ascend, oh my Soul, with the wings of the lark
ascend!

Soaring away and away far into the blue.
Or with the shrill seagull to the breakers bend,
Or with the bee, where the grasses and field-flowers
blend,
Drink out of golden cups of the honey-dew.

Ascend, oh my Soul, on the wings of the wind as it
blows,
Striking wild organ-blasts from the forest trees,
Or on the zephyr bear love of the rose to the rose,
Or with the hurricane sower cast seed as he goes
Limitless ploughing the leagues of the sibilant
seas.

Ascend, oh my Soul, on the wings of the choral
strain,
Invisible tier above tier upbuilding sublime;
Note as it scales after note in a rhythmical chain
Reaching from chaos and welter of struggle and
pain,
Far into vistas empyreal receding from time.

Ascend! take wing on the thoughts of the Dead, my
Soul,

Breathing in colour and stone, flashing through
epic and song:
Thoughts that like avalanche snows gather force as
they roll,
Mighty to fashion and knead the phenomenal throng
Of generations of men as they thunder along.

THE ASCENT OF MAN.

PART I.

As compressed within the bounded
 shell
Boundless Ocean seems to surge and
 swell,
Haunting echoes of an infinite whole
Moan and murmur through Man's
 finite soul.

CHAUNTS OF LIFE.

I.

Struck out of dim fluctuant forces and shock of
 electrical vapour,
Repelled and attracted the atoms flashed mingling in
 union primeval,
And over the face of the waters far heaving in
 limitless twilight
Auroral pulsations thrilled faintly, and, striking the
 blank heaving surface,
The measureless speed of their motion now leaped
 into light on the waters.
And lo, from the womb of the waters, upheaved in
 volcanic convulsion,
Ribbed and ravaged and rent there rose bald peaks
 and the rocky
Heights of confederate mountains compelling the
 fugitive vapours

To take a form as they passed them and float as
clouds through the azure.
Mountains, the broad-bosomed mothers of torrents
and rivers perennial,
Feeding the rivers and plains with patient
persistence, till slowly,
In the swift passage of æons recorded in stone by
Time's graver,
There germ grey films of the lichen and mosses and
palm-ferns gigantic,
And jungle of tropical forest fantastical branches
entwining,
And limitless deserts of sand and wildernesses
primeval.

II.

Lo, moving o'er chaotic waters,
Love dawned upon the seething
waste,
Transformed in ever new avatars
It moved without or pause or haste:
Like sap that moulds the leaves of
May
It wrought within the ductile clay.

And vaguely in the pregnant deep,
Clasped by the glowing arms of
light
From an eternity of sleep
Within unfathomed gulfs of night
A pulse stirred in the plastic slime
Responsive to the rhythm of Time.

Enkindled in the mystic dark
Life built herself a myriad forms,

And, flashing its electric spark
Through films and cells and pulps
and worms,
Flew shuttlewise above, beneath,
Weaving the web of life and death.

And multiplying in the ocean,
Amorphous, rude, colossal things
Lolled on the ooze in lazy motion,
Armed with grim jaws or uncouth
wings;
Helpless to lift their cumbering bulk
They lurch like some dismasted hulk.

And virgin forest, verdant plain,
The briny sea, the balmy air,
Each blade of grass and globe of rain,
And glimmering cave and gloomy
lair
Began to swarm with beasts and
birds,
With floating fish and fleet-foot
herds.

The lust of life's delirious fires
Burned like a fever in their blood,
Now pricked them on with fierce
desires,
Now drove them famishing for
food,
To seize coy females in the fray,
Or hotly hunted hunt for prey.

And amorously urged them on
In wood or wild to court their
mate,
Proudly displaying in the sun
With antics strange and looks elate,

The vigour of their mighty thews
Or charm of million-coloured hues.

There crouching 'mid the scarlet
 bloom,
 Voluptuously the leopard lies,
And through the tropic forest gloom
 The flaming of his feline eyes
Stirs with intoxicating stress
The pulses of the leopardess.

Or two swart bulls of self-same age
 Meet furiously with thunderous
 roar,
And lash together, blind with rage,
 And clanging horns that fain would
 gore
Their rival, and so win the prize
Of those impassive female eyes.

Or in the nuptial days of spring,
 When April kindles bush and brier,
Like rainbows that have taken wing,
 Or palpitating gems of fire,
Bright butterflies in one brief day
Live but to love and pass away.

And herds of horses scour the plains,
 The thickets scream with bird and
 beast
The love of life burns in their veins,
 And from the mightiest to the least
Each preys upon the other's life
In inextinguishable strife.

War rages on the teeming earth;
 The hot and sanguinary fight
Begins with each new creature's birth:

A dreadful war where might is
right;
Where still the strongest slay and
win,
Where weakness is the only sin.

There is no truce to this drawn battle,
Which ends but to begin again;
The drip of blood, the hoarse death-
rattle,
The roar of rage, the shriek of pain,
Are rife in fairest grove and dell,
Turning earth's flowery haunts to hell.

A hell of hunger, hatred, lust,
Which goads all creatures here
below,
Or blindworm wriggling in the dust,
Or penguin in the Polar snow:
A hell where there is none to save,
Where life is life's insatiate grave.

And in the long portentous strife,
Where types are tried even as by
fire,
Where life is whetted upon life
And step by panting step mounts
higher,
Apes lifting hairy arms now stand
And free the wonder-working hand.

They raise a light, aërial house
On shafts of widely branching
trees,
Where, harboured warily, each spouse
May feed her little ape in peace,
Green cradled in his heaven-roofed
bed,

Leaves rustling lullabies o'erhead.

And lo, 'mid reeking swarms of earth
Grim struggling in the primal
wood,
A new strange creature hath its birth:
Wild—stammering—nameless—
shameless—nude;
Spurred on by want, held in by fear,
He hides his head in caverns drear.

Most unprotected of earth's kin,
His fight for life that seems so vain
Sharpens his senses, till within
The twilight mazes of his brain,
Like embryos within the womb,
Thought pushes feelers through the
gloom.

And slowly in the fateful race
It grows unconscious, till at length
The helpless savage dares to face
The cave-bear in his grisly
strength;
For stronger than its bulky thews
He feels a force that grows with use.

From age to dumb unnumbered age,
By dim gradations long and slow,
He reaches on from stage to stage,
Through fear and famine, weal and
woe
And, compassed round with danger,
still
Prolongs his life by craft and skill.

With cunning hand he shapes the
flint,

He carves the horn with strange
device,
He splits the rebel block by dint
Of effort—till one day there flies
A spark of fire from out the stone:
Fire which shall make the world his
own.

III.

And from the clash of warring
Nature's strife
Man day by day wins his imperilled
life;
For, goaded on by want, he hunts the
roe,
Chases the deer, and lays the wild
boar low.
In his rude boat made of the hollow
trees
He drifts adventurous on the unoared
seas,
And, as he tilts upon the rocking tide,
Catches the glistening fish that flash
and glide
Innumerable through the waters wide.
He'll fire the bush whose flames shall
help him fel
The trunks to prop his roof, where he
may dwell
Beside the bubbling of a crystal well,
Sheltered from drenching rains or
noxious glare
When the sun holds the zenith.
Delving there,

His cumbered wife, whose
 multifarious toil
Seems never done, breaks the rich
 virgin soil,
And in the ashes casts the casual
 seeds
Of feathered grass and efflorescent
 weeds;
When, as with thanks, the bounteous
 earth one morn
Returns lush blades of life-sustaining
 corn.
And while the woman digs and
 plants, and twines
To precious use long reeds and pliant
 bines,
He—having hit the brown bird on the
 wing,
And slain the roe—returns at
 evening,
And gives his spoil unto her, to
 prepare
The succulent, wildwood scented,
 simmering fare,
While with impatient sniffs and
 eager-eyed
His bronze-limbed children gather to
 his side.
And, when the feast is done, all take
 their ease,
Lulled by the sing-song of the
 evening breeze
And murmuring undertones of many-
 foliated trees;
While here and there through rifts of
 green the sky

Casts its blue glance like an all-
seeing eye.
But though by stress of want and
poignant need
Man tames the wolf-sprung hound
and rearing steed,
Pens up the ram, and yokes the deep-
horned ox,
And through wide pastures shepherds
woolly flocks;
Though age by age, through
discipline of toil,
Man wring a richer harvest from the
soil,
And in the grim and still renewing
fight
Slays loathly worms and beasts of
gruesome might
By the close-knitted bondage of the
clan,
Which adding up the puny strength of
man
Makes thousands move with one
electric thrill
Of simultaneous, energetic will;
Yet still behind the narrow borderland
Where in security he seems to stand,
His apprehensive life is compassed
round
By baffling mysteries he cannot
sound,
Where, big with terrors and
calamities,
The future like a foe in ambush lies:
A muffled foe, that seems to watch
and wait

With the Medusa eyes of stony fate.

—

Great floods o'erwhelm and ruin his
 ripening grain,
His boat is shattered by the hurricane,
From the rent cloud the tameless
 lightning springs—
Heaven's flame-mouthed dragon with
 a roar of wings—
And fires his hut and simple
 household things;
Until before his horror-stricken eyes
The stored-up produce of long labour
 lies,
A heap of ashes smoking 'neath the
 skies.—
Or now the pastures where his flocks
 did graze,
Parched, withered, shrivelled by the
 imminent blaze
Of the great ball of fire that glares
 above,
Glow dry like iron heated in a stove;
Turning upon themselves, the tortured
 sheep,
With blackening tongues, drop heap
 on gasping heap,
Their rotting flesh sickens the wind
 that moans
And whistles poisoned through their
 chattering bones;
While the thin shepherd, staring sick
 and gaunt,
Will search the thorns for berries, or
 yet haunt
The stony channels of some river-bed

Where filtering fresh perchance a
liquid thread
Of water may run clear.—Now dark
o'erhead,
Thickening with storm, the wintry
clouds will loom,
And wrap the land in weeds of
mournful gloom;
Shrouding the sun and every lesser
light
Till earth with all her aging woods
grows white,
And hurrying streams stop fettered in
their flight.
Then famished beasts freeze by the
frozen lakes,
And thick as leaves dead birds
bestrew the brakes;
And, cowering blankly by the
flickering flame,
Man feels a presence without form or
name,
When by the bodies of his speechless
dead
In barbarous woe he bows his
stricken head.
Then in the hunger of his piteous love
He sends his thought, winged like a
carrier dove—
Through the unanswering silence
void and vast,
Whence from dim hollows blows an
icy blast—
To bring some sign, some little sign at
last,
From his lost chiefs—the beautiful,
the brave—

Vanished like bubbles on a breaking
 wave,
Lost in the unfathomed darkness of
 the grave.
When, lo, behold beside him in the
 night,—
Softly beside him, like the noiseless
 light
Of moonbeams moving o'er the
 glimmering floor
That come unbidden through the
 bolted door,—
The lonely sleeper sees the lost one
 stand
Like one returned from some dim,
 distant land,
Bending towards him with his
 outstretched hand.
But when he fain would grasp it in
 his own,
He melts into thin moonshine and is
 gone—
A spirit now, who on the other shore
Of death hunts happily for evermore.

—
A Son of Life, but dogged, while he
 draws breath,
By her inseparable shadow—death,
Man, feeble Man, whom unknown
 Fates appal,
With prayer and praise seeks to
 propitiate all
The spirits, who, for good or evil
 plight,
Bless him in victory or in sickness
 smite.

Those are his Dead who, wrapped in
 grisly shrouds,
Now ride phantasmal on the rushing
 clouds,
Souls of departed chiefs whose livid
 forms
He sees careering on the reinless
 storms,
Wild, spectral huntsmen who
 tumultuously,
With loud halloo and shrilly echoing
 cry,
Follow the furious chase, with the
 whole pack
Of shadowy hounds fierce yelping in
 the track
Of wolves and bears as shadowy as
 the hosts
Who lead once more as unsubstantial
 ghosts
Their lives of old as restlessly they
 fly
Across the wildernesses of the sky.
When the wild hunt is done, shall
 they not rest
Their heads upon some swan-white
 maiden's breast,
And quaff their honeyed mead with
 godlike zest
In golden-gated Halls whence they
 may see
The earth and marvellous secrets of
 the Sea
Whereon the clouds will lie with grey
 wings furled,
And in whose depths, voluminously
 curled,

The serpent looms whose girth
engirds the world?
Far, far above now in supernal power
Those spirits rule the sunshine and
the shower!
How shall he win their favour; yea,
how move
To pity the unpitying gods above,
The Dæmon rulers of life's fitful
dream,
Who sway men's destinies, and still
would seem
To treat them lightly as a game of
chance,
The sport of whim and blindfold
circumstance—
The irresponsible, capricious gods,
So quick to please or anger; whose
sharp rods
Are storms and lightnings launched
from cloven skies;
Who feast upon the shuddering
victim's cries,
The smell of blood, and human
sacrifice.
But ever as Man grows they grow
with him;
Terrific, cruel, gentle, bright, or dim,
With eyes of dove-like mercy, hands
of wrath,
Procession-like, they hover o'er his
path
And, changing with the gazer, borrow
light
From their rapt devotee's adoring
sight.

And Ormuzd, Ashtaroth, Osiris, Baal

—

Love spending gods and gods of
blood and wail—

Look down upon their suppliant from
the skies

With his own magnified, responsive
eyes.

For Man, from want and pressing
hunger freed,

Begins to feel another kind of need,
And in his shaping brain and through
his eyes

Nature, awakening, sees her blue-
arched skies;

The Sun, his life-begetter, isled in
space;

The Moon, the Measurer of his span
of days;

The immemorial stars who pierce his
night

With inklings of things vast and
infinite.

All shows of heaven and earth that
move and pass

Take form within his brain as in a
glass.

The tidal thunder of the sea now roars
And breaks symphonious on a
hundred shores;

The fitful flutings of the vagrant
breeze

Strike gusts of sound from virgin
forest trees;

White leaping waters of wild
cataracts fall

From crag and jag in lapses musical,

And streams meandering amid
 daisied leas
Throb with the pulses of tumultuous
 seas.
From hills and valleys smoking mists
 arise,
Steeped in pale gold and amethystine
 dyes.
The land takes colour from him, and
 the flowers
Laugh in his path like sun-dyed April
 showers.
The moving clouds in calm or
 thunderstorm,
All shows of things in colour, sound,
 or form
Moulded mysteriously, are freshly
 wrought
Within the fiery furnace of his
 thought.

IV.

 No longer Nature's thrall,
 Man builds the city wall
That shall withstand her league of
 levelling storms;
 He builds tremendous
 tombs
 Where, hid in hoarded
 glooms,
His dead defy corruption with her
 worms:
High towers he rears and bulks of
 glowing stone,

Where the king rules upon a golden
throne.

 Creature of hopes and fears,
 Of mirth and many tears,
He makes himself a thousand costly
altars,
 Whence smoke of sacrifice,
 Fragrant with myrrh and
 spice,
Ascends to heaven as the flame leaps
and falters;
Where, like a king above the Cloud
control,
God sits enthroned and rules Man's
subject soul.

 Yet grievous here below
 And manifold Man's woe;
Though he can stay the flood and
bind the waters,
 His hand he shall not stay
 That bids him sack and slay
And turn the waving fields to fields
of slaughters;
And, as he reaps War's harvest grim
and gory,
Commits a thousand crimes and calls
it glory.

 Vast empires fall and rise,
 As when in sunset skies
The monumental clouds lift flashing
towers
 With turrets, spires, and
 bars
 Lit by confederate stars

Till the bright rack dissolves in flying
showers:
Kingdoms on kingdoms have their
fleeting day,
Dazzle the conquered world, and pass
away.

In golden Morning lands
The blazing crowns change
hands,
From mystic Ind to fleshly Babylon,
Assyria, Palestine
Armed with her book
divine,
Dread Persia whose fleet chariots
charged and won
Pale Continents where prostrate
monarchs kneel
Before the flash of her resistless steel.

As one by one they start
With proudly beating heart
Fast in the furious, fierce-contested
race,
Where neck to neck they
strain
Deliriously to gain
The winning post of power, the meed
of praise;
Some drop behind, fall, or are
trampled down
While the proud victor grasps the
laurel crown.

Not only great campaigns
Shall glorify their reigns,

But high-towered cities wondrous to
 behold,
 With gardens poised in air
 Like bowers of Eden fair,
With brazen gates and shrines of
 beaten gold,
And Palace courts whose constellated
 lights
Shine on black slaves and cringing
 satellites.

 Eclipsing with her fate
 Each power and rival state
With her unnumbered stretch of
 generations,
 A sand-surrounded isle
 Fed by the bounteous Nile,
Egypt confronts Sahara—sphinx of
 nations;
Taught by the floods that make or
 mar her shore,
She scans the stars and hoards
 mysterious lore.

 Hers are imperial halls
 With strangely scripted
 walls
And long perspectives of memorial
 places,
 Where the hushed daylight
 glows
 On mute colossal rows
Of clawed wild beasts featured with
 female faces,
And realmless kings inane whose
 stony eyes

Have watched the hour-glass of the
centuries.

There in the rainless sands
The toil of captive hands,
That aye must do as their taskmaster
bids,
Through years of dusty
days
Brick by slow brick shall
raise
The incarnate pride of kings—the
Pyramids—
Linked with some name synonymous
with slaughter
Time has effaced like a name writ in
water.

For ever with fateful
shocks,
Roar as of hurtling rocks,
Start fresh embattled hosts with flags
unfurled,
To meet on battle-fields
With clash of spears and
shields,
Widowing the world of men to win
the world:
The hissing air grows dark with iron
rain,
And groans the earth beneath her
sheaves of slain.

Triumphant o'er them all,
See crowns and sceptres
fall

Before the arms of iron-soldered
legions;
As Capitolian Rome
Across the salt sea foam
Orders her Cæsars to remotest
regions:
From silver Spain and Albion's
clouded seas
To the fair shrines and marble mines
of Greece.

Pallas unmatched in war,
To her triumphal car
Rome chains fallen despots and
discrownèd queens
With many a rampant beast,
Birds from the gorgeous
East,
And wool-haired Nubians torn from
tropic scenes;
There huge barbarians from Druidic
woods
Tower ominous o'er the humming
multitudes;

For still untamed and free
In loathed captivity,
Their spirits bend not to the
conqueror's yoke,
Though for a Roman sight
They must in mimic fight
Give wounds in play and deal Death's
mortal stroke,
While round the arena rings the fierce
applause
Voluptuous, as their bubbling life-
blood flows

In streams of purple rain
From hecatombs of slain
Saluting Cæsar still with failing
 breath,
 But in their dying souls
 Undying hate, which rolls
From land to land the avalanche of
 Death,
That, gathering volume as it sweeps
 along,
Pours down the Alps throng on
 unnumbered throng.

 From northern hills and
 plains
 Storm-lashed by driving
 rains,
From moorland wastes and depths of
 desolate wood,
 From many an icebound
 shore,
 The human torrents pour,
Horde following upon horde as flood
 on flood,
Avengers of the slain they come, they
 come,
And break in thunder on the walls of
 Rome.

 A trembling people waits
 As, surging through its
 gates,
Break the fierce Goths with trumpet-
 blasts of doom;
 And many a glorious shrine
 Begins to flare and shine,

And many a palace flames up through
the gloom,
Kindled like torches by relentless
wrath
To light the Spoiler on destruction's
path.

Yea, with Rome's ravished
walls,
The old world tottering
falls
And crumbles into ruin wide and
vast;
The Empire seems to rock
As with an earthquake's
shock,
And vassal provinces look on aghast;
As realms are split and nation rent
from nation,
The globe seems drifting to
annihilation.

V.

"Peace on earth and good will unto
Men!"
Came the tidings borne o'er wide
dominions;
The glad tidings thrilled the world
as when
Spring comes fluttering on the west
wind's pinions,
When her voice is heard
Warbling through each bird,
And a new-born hope

Throbs through all things infinite
in scope.

"Peace on earth and good will!"
came the word
Of the Son of Man, the Man of
Sorrow—
But the peace turned to a flaming
sword,
Turned to woe and wailing on the
morrow
When with gibes and
scorns,
Crowned with barren
thorns,
Gashed and crucified,
On the Cross the tortured Jesus
died.

And the world, once full of flower-
hung shrines,
Now forsakes old altars for the new,
Zeus grows faint and Venus' star
declines
As Jehovah glorifies the Jew,
He whom—lit with awe—
God-led Moses saw,
Graving with firm hand
In his people's heart his Lord's
command.

Holding Hells and Heavens in
either hand
Comes the priest and comes the wild-
eyed prophet,
Tells the people of some happier
land,

Terrifies them with a burning Tophet;
Gives them creeds for
bread
And warm roof o'erhead,
Gives for life's delight
Passports to the kingdom, spirit-
bright.

And the people groaning
everywhere
Hearken gladly to the wondrous story,
How beyond this life of toil and
care
They shall lead a life of endless
glory:
Where beyond the dim
Earth-mists Seraphim,
Love-illumined, wait—
Hierarchies of angels at heaven's
gate.

Let them suffer while they live
below,
Bear in silence weariness and pain;
For the heavier is their earthly woe,
Verily the heavenlier is their gain
In the mansions where
Sorrow and despair,
Yea, all moan shall cease
With the moan of immemorial
seas.

And to save their threatened souls
from sin,
Save them from the world, the flesh,
the devil,

Men and Women break from bonds
of kin
And in cloistered cell draw bar on
evil,
Worship on their knees
Sacred Images,
And all Saints above,
The Madonna, mystic Rose of
love.

Mystic Rose of Maiden
Motherhood,
Moon of Hearts immaculately mild,
Beaming o'er the turbulent times
and rude
With the promise of her blessèd
Child:
Whom pale Monks adore,
Pining evermore
For the heaven of love
Which their homesick lives are
dying of.

But the flame of mystical desires
Turns to fury fiercer than a leopard's,
Holy fagots blaze with kindling
fires
As the priests, the people's careful
shepherds,
In Heaven's awful name,
Set the pile on flame
Where, for Conscience'
sake,
Heretics burn chaunting at the
stake.

Subterranean secrets of the prison,

Throbs of anguish in the crushing
cell,
Torture-chambers of the Inquisition
Are the Church's antidotes to Hell.
Better rack them here,
Mutilate and sear,
Than their souls should go
To the place of everlasting woe.

And a lurid universal night,
Lit by quenchless fires for
unquenched sages,
Thick with spectral broods that
shun the light,
Looms impervious o'er the stifled
ages
Where the blameless wise
Fall a sacrifice,
Fall as fell of old
The unspotted firstlings of the fold.

And the violent feud of clashing
creeds
Shatters empires and breaks realms
asunder;
Cities tremble, sceptres shake like
reeds
At the swift bolts of the Papal
thunder;
Yea, the bravest quail,
Cast from out the pale
Of all Christendom
By the dread anathemas of Rome.

And like one misled by marish
gleams

When he hears the shrill cock's note
 of warning,
Europe, starting from its trance of
 dreams,
Sees the first streak of the clear-eyed
 morning
 As it broadening stands
 Over ravaged lands
 Where mad nations are
Locked in grip of fratricidal war.

Castles burn upon the vine-clad
 knolls,
Huts glow smouldering in the
 trampled meadows;
And a hecatomb of martyred souls
Fills a queenly town with wail of
 widows
 In those branded hours
 When red-guttering
 showers
 Splash by courts and stews
To the Bells of Saint
 Bartholomew's.

Seed that's sown upon the wanton
 wind
Shall be harvested in whirlwind
 rages,
For revenge and hate bring forth
 their kind,
And black crime must ever be the
 wages
 Of a nation's crime
 Time transmits to time,
 Till the score of years

Is wiped out in floods of
 staunchless tears.

Yea, the anguish in a people's life
May have eaten out its heart of pity,
 Bred in scenes of scarlet sin and
 strife,
Heartless splendours of a haughty
 city;
 Dark with lowering fate,
 At the massive gate
 Of its kings it may
Stand and knock with tragic hand
 one day.

For the living tomb gives up its
 dead,
Bastilles yawn, and chains are rent
 asunder,
 Little children now and hoary
 head,
Man and maiden, meet in joy and
 wonder;
 Throng on radiant throng,
 Brave and blithe and
 strong,
 Gay with pine and palm,
Fill fair France with freedom's
 thunder-psalm.

Free and equal—rid of king and
 priest—
The rapt nation bids each neighbour
 nation
 To partake the sacramental feast
And communion of the Federation:
 And electrified

Masses, far and wide,
Thrill to hope and start
Vibrating as with one common
heart.

From the perfumed South of
amorous France
With her wreath of orange bloom and
myrtle,
From old wizard woods of lost
Romance
Soft with wail of wind and voice of
turtle,
From the roaring sea
Of grey Normandy,
And the rich champagnes
Where the vine gads o'er
Burgundian plains;

From the banks of the blue arrowy
Rhone,
And from many a Western
promontory,
From volcanic crags of cloven
stone
Crowned with castles ivy-green in
story;
From gay Gascon coasts
March fraternal hosts,
Equal hosts and free,
Pilgrims to the shrine of liberty.

But king calls on king in wild
alarms,
Troops march threatening through the
vales and passes,

Barefoot Faubourgs at the cry to
arms
On the frontier hurl their desperate
masses:
The deep tocsin's boom
Fills the streets with gloom,
And with iron hand
The red Terror guillotines the land.

For the Furies of the sanguine past
Chase fair Freedom, struggling torn
and baffled,
Till infuriate—turned to bay at last

—
Rolled promiscuous on the common
scaffold,
Vengeful she shall smite
A Queen's head bleached
white,
And a courtesan's
Whose light hands once held the
reins of France.

She shall smite and spare not—
yea, her own,
Her fair sons so pure from all
pollution,
With their guiltless life-blood must
atone
To the goddess of the Revolution;
Dying with a song
On their lips, her young
Ardent children end,
Meeting death even as one meets a
friend.

And her daughter, in heroic shame,

Turned to Freedom's Moloch statue,
crying:
"Liberty, what crimes done in thy
name!"
Spake, and with her Freedom's self
seemed dying
As she bleeding lay
'Neath Napoleon's sway:
Europe heard her knell
When on Waterloo the Empire fell.

VI.

Woe, woe to Man and all his hapless
brood!
No rest for him, no peace is to be
found;
He may have tamed wild beasts
and made the ground
Yield corn and wine and every kind
of food;
He may have turned the ocean to
his steed,
Tutored the lightning's elemental
speed
To flash his thought from Ætna to
Atlantic;
He may have weighed the stars and
spanned the stream,
And trained the fiery force of
panting steam
To whirl him o'er vast steppes, and
heights gigantic:
But the storm-lashed world of
feeling—

Love, the fount of tears
 unsealing,
Choruses of passion pealing—
 Lust, ambition, hatred, awe,
 Clashing loudly with the law,
 But the phantasms of the mind
 Who shall master, yea, who
 bind!

What help is there without, what hope
 within
Of rescue from the immemorial
 strife?
What will redeem him from the
 spasm of life,
With all its devious ways of shame
 and sin?
What will redeem him from
 ancestral greeds,
Grey legacies of hate and hoar
 misdeeds,
Which from the guilty past Man doth
 inherit—
The past that is bound up with him,
 and part
Of the pulsations of his inmost
 heart,
And of the vital motions of his spirit?
Ages mazed in tortuous errors,
Ghostly fears, and haunting
 terrors,
Minds bewitched that served as
 mirrors
For the foulest fancies bred
In a fasting hermit's head,
Such as cast a sickly blight
On all shapes of life and light.

Yea, panting and pursued and stung
and driven,
The soul of Man flies on in deep
distress,
As once across the world's harsh
wilderness
Latona fled, chased by the Queen of
heaven;
Flying across the homeless
Universe
From the inveterate stroke of
Juno's curse;
On whom even mother earth closed
all her portals,
Refusing shelter in her cooing
bowers,
Or rest upon her velvet couch of
flowers,
To the most weary of all weary
mortals.
Within whose earth-encumbered
form,
Like two fair stars entwined in
storm,
Or wings astir within the worm,
Feeling out for light and air,
Struggled that celestial pair,
Phœbus of unerring bow,
And chaste Dian fair as snow.

Ah, who will harbour her? Ah, who
will save
The fugitive from pangs that rack
and tear;
Who, finding rest nor refuge
anywhere,

Seems doomed to be her unborn
 offspring's grave;
The seed of Jove, murdered before
 their birth—
Did not the sea, more merciful than
 earth,
Bid Delos stand—that wandering isle
 of Ocean—
Stand motionless upon the moving
 foam,
To be the exile's wave-encircled
 home,
And lull her pains with leaves in
 drowsy motion,
Where the soft-boughed olive
 sighing
Bends above the woman lying
And in spasms of anguish
 crying,
Shuddering through her
 mortal frame,
As from dust is struck the
 flame
Which shall henceforth beam
 sublime
Through the firmament of
 Time?

Oh, balmy Island bedded on the
 brine,
Harbour of refuge on the tumbling
 seas,
The fabulous bowers of the
 Hesperides
Ne'er bore such blooming gold as
 glows in thine:

Thou green Oasis on the tides of
Time
Where no rude blast disturbs the
azure clime;
Thou Paradise whence man can ne'er
be driven,
Where, severed from the world-
clang and the roar,
Still in the flesh he yet may reach
that shore
Where want is not, and, like the dew
from heaven,
There drops upon the fevered
soul
The balm of Thought's divine
control
And rapt absorption in the
whole:
Delivery in the realm of art
Of the world-racked human
heart—
Forms and hues and sounds
that make
Life grow lovelier for their
sake.

By sheer persistence, strenuous and
slow,
The marble yields and, line by
flowing line
And curve by curve, begins to
swell and shine
Beneath the ring of each far-sighted
blow:
Until the formless block obeys the
hand,

And at the mastering mind's
supreme command
Takes form and radiates from each
limb and feature
Such beauty as ne'er bloomed in
mortal mould,
Whose face, out-smiling centuries,
shall hold
Perfection's mirror up to 'prentice
nature.

Not from out voluptuous ocean
Venus rose in balanced motion,
Goddess of all bland emotion;
But she leaped a shape of
light,
Radiating love's delight,
From the sculptor's brain to be
Sphered in immortality.

New spirit-yearnings for a heavenlier
mood
Call for a love more pitiful and
tender,
And 'neath the painter's touch
blooms forth in splendour
The image of transfigured
motherhood.
All hopes of all glad women who
have smiled
In adoration on their first-born
child
Here smile through one glad woman
made immortal;
All tears of all sad women through
whose heart
Has pierced the edge of sorrow's
sevenfold dart

Lie weeping with her at death's
dolorous portal.
For in married hues whose
splendour
Bodies forth the gloom and
grandeur
Of life's pageant, tragic, tender,
Common things transfigured
flush
By the magic of the brush,
As when sun-touched
raindrops glow,
Blent in one harmonious bow.

But see, he comes, Lord of life's
changeable shows,
To whom the ways of Nature are
laid bare,
Who looks on heaven and makes
the heavens more fair,
And adds new sweetness to the
perfumed rose;
Who can unseal the heart with all its
tears,
Marshal loves, hates, hopes, sorrows,
joys, and fears
In quick procession o'er the passive
pages;
Who has given tongue to silent
generations
And wings to thought, so that long-
mouldered nations
May call to nations o'er the abyss of
ages:
The poet, in whose shaping
brain
Life is created o'er again

With loftier raptures, loftier
pain;
Whose mighty potencies of
verse
Move through the plastic
Universe,
And fashion to their strenuous
will
The world that is creating
still.

Do you hear it, do you hear it
Soaring up to heaven, or
somewhere near it?
From the depths of life upheaving,
Clouds of earth and sorrow
cleaving,
From despair and death retrieving,
All triumphant blasts of sound
Lift you at one rhythmic bound
From the thralldom of the ground.

All the sweetness which the
glowing
Violets waft to west winds
blowing,
All the burning love-notes aching,
Rills and thrills of rapture shaking
Through the hearts that throb to
breaking
Of the little nightingales;
Mellow murmuring waters
streaming
Lakeward in long silver trails,

Crooning low while earth lies
dreaming
To the moonlight-tangled vales;
Swish of rain on half-blown roses
Hoarding close their rich
perfume,
Which the summer dawn uncloses
Sparkling in their morning
bloom;
Convent peals o'er pastoral
meadows,
Swinging through hay-scented
air
When the velvet-footed shadows
Call the hind to evening prayer.
Yea, all notes of woods and
highlands;
Sea-fowls' screech round sphinx-
like islands
Couched among the Hebrides;
Cuckoo calls through April
showers,
When the green fields froth with
flowers
And with bloom the orchard
trees.
Boom of surges with their hollow
Refluent shock from cave to
cave,
As the maddening spring tides
follow
Moonstruck reeling wave o'er
wave.
Yea, all rhythms of air and ocean
Married to the heart's emotion,
To the interwoven emotion
Of the heart for ever turning

In a whirl of bliss and pain,
Blending in symphonious strain
All the vague, unearthly yearning
Of the visionary brain.

All life's discords sweetly blending,
Heights on heights of being
 ascending,
 Harmonies of confluent sound
 Lift you at one rhythmic bound
 From the thralldom of the ground;
Loosen all your bonds of birth,
Clogs of sense and weights of earth,
 Bear you in angelic legions
 High above terrestrial regions
Into ampler ether, where
Spirits breathe a finer air,
 Where upon world altitudes
 God-intoxicated moods
 Fill you with beatitudes;
Till no longer cramped and bound
By the narrow human round,
 All the body's barriers slide,
 Which with cold obstruction hide
The supreme, undying, sole
Spirit struggling through the whole,
 And no more a thing apart
 From the universal heart
 Liberated by the grace
 Of man's genius for a space,
 Human lives dissolve, enlase
 In a flaming world embrace.

A SYMBOL.

Hurrying for ever in their restless
flight
The generations of earth's teeming
womb
Rise into being and lapse into the
tomb
Like transient bubbles sparkling in
the light;
They sink in quick succession out of
sight
Into the thick insuperable gloom
Our futile lives in flashing by
illuminate—
Lightning which mocks the darkness
of the night.

Nay—but consider, though we
change and die,
If men must pass shall Man not
still remain?
As the unnumbered drops of
summer rain
Whose changing particles unchanged
on high,
Fixed, in perpetual motion, yet
maintain
The mystic bow emblazoned on the
sky.

TIME'S SHADOW.

Thy life, O Man, in this brief moment
lies:
Time's narrow bridge whereon we
darkling stand,
With an infinitude on either hand

Receding luminously from our eyes.
Lo, there thy Past's forsaken Paradise
 Subsideth like some visionary
 strand,
While glimmering faint, the
 Future's promised land,
Illusive from the abyss, seems fain to
 rise.

This hour alone Hope's broken
 pledges mar,
And Joy now gleams before, now
 in our rear,
Like mirage mocking in some waste
 afar,
Dissolving into air as we draw
 near.
Beyond our steps the path is
 sunny-clear,
The shadow lying only where we are.

THE ASCENT OF MAN.

PART II.

"Love is for ever poor, and so far from being delicate and beautiful, as mankind imagined, he is squalid and withered ... homeless and unsandalled; he sleeps without covering before the doors, and in the unsheltered streets."—PLATO.

THE PILGRIM SOUL.

Through the winding mazes of windy
 streets

Blindly I hurried I knew not whither,
Through the dim-lit ways of the brain
thus fleets

A fluttering dream driven hither and
thither.—
The fitful flare of the moon fled fast,
Like a sickly smile now seeming to
wither,

Now dark like a scowl in the hurrying
blast
As ominous shadows swept over the
roofs
Where white as a ghost the scared
moonlight had passed.

Curses came mingled with wails and
reproofs,
With doors banging to and the
crashing of glass,
With the baying of dogs and the
clatter of hoofs,

With the rush of the river as, huddling
its mass
Of weltering water towards the deep
ocean,
'Neath many-arched bridges its eddies
did pass.

A hubbub of voices in savage
commotion
Was mixed with the storm in a chaos
of sound,
And thrilled as with ague in
shuddering emotion

I fled as the hunted hare flees from
the hound.
Past churches whose bells were
tumultuously ringing
The year in, and clashing in concord
around;

Past the deaf walls of dungeons
whose curses seemed clinging
To the tempest that shivered and
shrieked in amazement;
Past brightly lit mansions whence
music and singing

Came borne like a scent through the
close-curtained casement,
To vaults in whose shadow wild
outcasts were hiding
Their misery deep in the gloom of the
basement.

By vociferous taverns where women
were biding
With features all withered, distorted,
aghast;
Some sullenly silent, some brutally
chiding,

Some reeling away into gloom as I
passed
On, on, through lamp-lighted and
fountain-filled places,
Where throned in rich temples,
resplendent and vast,

The Lord of the City is deafened with
praises

As worshipping multitudes kneel as
of old;
Nor care for the crowds of
cadaverous faces,

The men that are marred and the
maids that are sold—
Inarticulate masses promiscuously
jumbled
And crushed 'neath their Juggernaut
idol of gold.

Lost lives of great cities bespattered
and tumbled,
Black rags the rain soaks, the wind
whips like a knout,
Were crouched in the streets there,
and o'er them nigh stumbled

A swarm of light maids as they
tripped to some rout.
The silk of their raiment voluptuously
hisses
And flaps o'er the flags as loud
laughing they flout

The wine-maddened men they ne'er
sate with kisses
For the pearls and the diamonds that
make them more fair,
For the flash of large jewels that fire
them with blisses,

For the glitter of gold in the gold of
their hair.
They smiled and they cozened, their
bold eyes shone brightly

And lightened with laughter, as, lit by
the flare

Of the wind-fretted gas-lamps, they
footed it lightly,
Or, closely enlacing and bowered in
gloom,
With mouth pressed to hot mouth,
their parched lips drain
nightly

The wine-cup of pleasure red-sealing
their doom.
Brief lives like bright rockets which,
aridly glowing,
Fall burnt out to ashes and reel to the
tomb.

On, on, loud and louder the rough
night was blowing,
Shrill singing was mixed with strange
cries of despair;
And high overhead the black sky,
redly glowing,

Loomed over the city one ominous
glare,
As dark yawning funnels from foul
throats for ever
Belched smoke grimly flaming,
which outraged the air.

On, on, by long quays where the
lamps in the river
Were writhing like serpents that hiss
ere they drown,
And poplars with palsy seemed
coldly to shiver,

On, on, to the bare desert end of the
town.

When lo! the wind stopped like a
heart that's ceased beating,
And nought but the waters, white
foaming and brown,

Were heard as to seaward their
currents went fleeting.
But hark! o'er the lull breaks a
desolate moan,
Like a little lost lamb's that is timidly
bleating

When, strayed from the shepherd, it
staggers alone
By tracks which the mountain
streams shake with their
thunder,
Where death seems to gape from each
boulder and stone.

I turned to the murmur: the clouds
swept asunder
And wheeled like white sea-gulls
around the white moon;
And the moon, like a white maid,
looked down in mute wonder

On a boy whose wan eyelids were
closed as in swoon.
Half nude on the ground he lay,
wasted and chilly,
And torn as with thorns and sharp
brambles of June;

His hair, like a flame which at
twilight burns stilly,

In a halo of light round his temples
was blown,
And his tears fell like rain on a storm-
stricken lily

Where he lay on the cold ground,
abandoned, alone.
With heart moved towards him in
wondering pity,
I tenderly seized his thin hand with
my own:

Crying, "Child, say how cam'st thou
so far from the city?
How cam'st thou alone in such pitiful
plight,
All blood-stained thy feet, with rags
squalid and gritty,

A waif by the wayside, unhoused in
the night?"
Then rose he and lifted the bright
locks, storm driven,
Which flamed round his forehead and
clouded his sight,

And mournful as meres on a
moorland at even
His blue eyes flashed wildly through
tears as they fell.
Strange eyes full of horror, yet fuller
of heaven,

Like eyes that from heaven have
looked upon hell.
The eyes of an angel whose depths
show where, burning

And lost in the pit, toss the angels
that fell.

"Ah," wailed he in tones full of
agonized yearning,
Like the plaintive lament of a
sickening dove
On a surf-beaten shore, whence it
sees past returning

The wings of the wild flock fast
fading above,
As they melt on the sky-line like
foam-flakes in motion:
So sadly he wailed, "I am Love! I am
Love!

"Behold me cast out as weed spurned
of the ocean,
Half nude on the bare ground, and
covered with scars
I perish of cold here;" and, choked
with emotion,

Gave a sob: at the low sob a shower
of stars
Broke shuddering from heaven, pale
flaming, and fell
Where the mid-city roared as with
rumours of wars.

"Be these God's tears?" I cried, as my
tears 'gan to well.
"Ah, Love, I have sought thee in
temples and towers,
In shrines where men pray, and in
marts where they sell;

"In tapestried chambers made tropic
with flowers,
Where amber-haired women, soft
breathing of spice,
Lay languidly lapped in the gold-
dropping showers

"Which gladdened and maddened
their amorous eyes.
I have looked for thee vainly in
churches where beaming
The Saints glowed embalmed in a
prism of dyes,

"Where wave over wave the rapt
music went streaming
With breakers of sound in full
anthems elate.
I have asked, but none knew thee, or
knew but thy seeming;

"A mask in thy likeness on high seats
of state;
And they bound it with gold, and they
crowned it with glory,
This thing they called love, which
was bond slave to hate.

"And they bowed down before it with
brown heads and hoary,
They worshipped it nightly, loud
hymning its praise,
While out in the cold blast, none
heeding its story,

"Love staggers, an outcast, with lust
in its place."

Love shivered and sighed like a reed
that is shaken,
And lifting his hunger-nipped face to
my face:

"Nay, if of the world I must needs die
forsaken,
Say thou wilt not leave me to dearth
and despair.
To thy heart, to thy home, let the exile
be taken,

"And feed me and shelter——"
"Where, outcast, ah, where?
Like thee I am homeless and spurned
of all mortals;
The House of my fathers yawns wide
to the air.

"Stalks desolation across the void
portals,
Hope lies aghast on the ruinous floor,
The halls that were thronged once
with star-browed immortals,

"With gods statue-still o'er the world-
whirr and roar,
With fauns of the forest and nymphs
of the river,
Are cleft as if lightning had struck to
their core.

"The luminous ceilings, where
soaring for ever
Dim hosts of plumed angels smoked
up to the sky,
With God-litten faces that yearned to
the giver

"As vapours of morning the sun
draws on high,
Now ravaged with rain hear the
hollow winds whistle
Through rifts in the rafters which
echo their cry.

"Blest walls that were vowed to the
Virgin now bristle
With weeds of sick scarlet and
plague-spotted moss,
And stained on the ground, choked
with thorn and rank thistle,

"Rots a worm-eaten Christ on a
mouldering Cross.
From the House of my fathers,
distraught, broken-hearted,
With a pang of immense,
irredeemable loss,

"On my wearying pilgrimage blindly
I started
To seek thee, oh Love, in high places
and low,
And instead of the glories for ever
departed,

"To warm my starved life in thy
mightier glow.
For I deemed thee a Presence ringed
round with all splendour,
With a sceptre in hand and a crown
on thy brow;

"And, behold, thou art helpless—
most helpless to tender

Thy service to others, who needest
their care.

Yea, now that I find thee a weak child
and slender,

"Exposed to the blast of the merciless
air,

Like a lamb that is shorn, like a leaf
that is shaken,

What, Love, now is left but to die in
despair?

"For Death is the mother of all the
forsaken,

The grave a strait bed where she
rocks them to rest,

And sleep, from whose silence they
never shall waken,

"The balm of oblivion she sheds on
their breast."

Then I seized him and led to the brink
of the river,

Where two storm-beaten seagulls
were fluttering west,

And the lamplight in drowning
seemed coldly to shiver,

And clasping Love close for the leap
from on high,

Said—"Let us go hence, Love; go
home, Love, for ever;

"For life casts us forth, and Man
dooms us to die."

As if stung by a snake the Child
shuddered and started,

And clung to me close with a
passionate cry:

"Stay with me, stay with me, poor,
broken-hearted;
Pain, if not pleasure, we two will
divide;
Though with the sins of the world I
have smarted,

"Though with the shame of the world
thou art dyed,
Weak as I am, on thy breast I'll
recover,
Worn as thou art, thou shalt bloom as
my bride:

"Bloom as the flower of the World for
the lover
Whom thou hast found in a lost little
Child."
And as he kissed my lips over and
over—

Child now, or Man, was it who thus
beguiled?—
Even as I looked on him, Love,
waxing slowly,
Grew as a little cloud, floating
enised,

Which spreads out aloft in the blue
sky till solely
It fills the deep ether tremendous in
height,
With far-flashing snow-peaks and
pinnacles wholly

Invisible, vanishing light within light.
So changing waxed Love—till he
 towered before me,
Outgrowing my lost gods in stature
 and might.

As he grew, as he drew me, a great
 awe came o'er me,
And stammering, I shook as I
 questioned his name;
But gently bowed o'er me, he soothèd
 and bore me,

Yea, bore once again to the haunts
 whence I came,
By dark ways and dreary, by rough
 roads and gritty,
To the penfolds of sin, to the purlieus
 of shame.

And lo, as we went through the woe-
 clouded city,
Where women bring forth and men
 labour in vain,
Weak Love grew so great in his
 passion of pity
That all who beheld him were born
 once again.

SAVING LOVE.

Would we but love what will not pass
 away!
The sun that on each morning
 shines as clear

As when it rose first on the world's
first year;
The fresh green leaves that rustle on
the spray.
The sun will shine, the leaves will be
as gay
When graves are full of all our
hearts held dear,
When not a soul of those who
loved us here,
Not one, is left us—creatures of
decay.

Yea, love the Abiding in the Universe
Which was before, and will be after
us.
Nor yet for ever hanker and vainly
cry
For human love—the beings that
change or die;
Die—change—forget: to care so is a
curse,
Yet cursed we'll be rather than not
care thus.

NIRVANA.

Divest thyself, O Soul, of vain desire!
Bid hope farewell, dismiss all
coward fears;
Take leave of empty laughter,
emptier tears,
And quench, for ever quench, the
wasting fire
Wherein this heart, as in a funeral
pyre,

Aye burns, yet is consumed not.
Years on years
Moaning with memories in thy
maddened ears—
Let at thy word, like refluent waves,
retire.

Enter thy soul's vast realm as
Sovereign Lord,
And, like that angel with the flaming
sword,
Wave off life's clinging hands.
Then chains will fall
From the poor slave of self's hard
tyranny—
And Thou, a ripple rounded by the
sea,
In rapture lost be lapped within the
All.

MOTHERHOOD.

From out the font of being, undefiled,
A life hath been upheaved with
struggle and pain;
Safe in her arms a mother holds
again
That dearest miracle—a new-born
child.
To moans of anguish terrible and wild
—
As shrieks the night-wind through
an ill-shut pane—
Pure heaven succeeds; and after
fiery strain

Victorious woman smiles serenely
mild.

Yea, shall she not rejoice, shall not
her frame
Thrill with a mystic rapture! At this
birth,
The soul now kindled by her vital
flame
May it not prove a gift of priceless
worth?
Some saviour of his kind whose
starry fame
Shall bring a brightness to the
darkened earth.

THE ASCENT OF MAN.

PART III.

"Our spirits have climbed
high
By reason of the passion of our grief,
—
And from the top of sense, looked
over sense
To the significance and heart of
things
Rather than things themselves."

E. B. BROWNING.

THE LEADING OF SORROW.

Through a twilight land, a moaning
region,
Thick with sighs that shook the
trembling air,
Land of shadows whose dim crew
was legion,
Lost I hurried, hunted by despair.
Quailed my heart like an expiring
splendour,
Fitful flicker of a faltering fire,
Smitten chords which tempest-
stricken render
Rhythms of anguish from a
breaking lyre.

Love had left me in a land of
shadows,
Lonely on the ruins of delight,
And I grieved with tearless grief of
widows,
Moaned as orphans homeless in the
night.
Love had left me knocking at Death's
portal—
Shone his star and vanished from
my sky—
And I cried: "Since Love, even Love,
is mortal,
Take, unmake, and break me; let
me die."

Then, the twilight's grisly veils
dividing,
Phantom-like there stole one o'er
the plain,
Wavering mists for ever round it
gliding

Hid the face I strove to scan in
vain.
Spake the veiled one: "Solitary
weeper,
'Mid the myriad mourners thou'rt
but one:
Come, and thou shalt see the awful
reaper,
Evil, reaping all beneath the sun."

On my hand the clay-cold hand did
fasten
As it murmured—"Up and follow
me;
O'er the thickly peopled earth we'll
hasten,
Yet more thickly packed with
misery."
And I followed: ever in the shadow
Of that looming form I fared along;
Now o'er mountains, now through
wood and meadow,
Or through cities with their surging
throng.

With none other for a friend or fellow
Those relentless footsteps were my
guide
To the sea-caves echoing with the
hollow
Immemorial moaning of the tide.
Laughed the sunlight on the living
ocean,
Danced and rocked itself upon the
spray,
And its shivered beams in twinkling
motion

Gleamed like star-motes in the
Milky Way.

Lo, beneath those waters surging,
 flowing,
I beheld the Deep's fantastic
 bowers;
Shapes which seemed alive and yet
 were growing
On their stalks like animated
 flowers.
Sentient flowers which seemed to
 glow and glimmer
Soft as ocean blush of Indian
 shells,
White as foam-drift in the moony
 shimmer
Of those sea-lit, wave-pavilioned
 dells.

Yet even here, as in the fire-eyed
 panther,
In disguise the eternal hunger lay,
For each feathery, velvet-tufted
 anther
Lay in ambush waiting for its prey.
Tiniest jewelled fish that flashed like
 lightning,
Blindly drawn, came darting
 through the wave,
When, a stifling sack above them
 tightening,
Closed the ocean-blossom's living
 grave.

Now we fared through forest glooms
 primeval

Through whose leaves the light but
rarely shone,
Where the buttressed tree-trunks
looked coeval
With the time-worn, ocean-fretted
stone;
Where, from stem to stem their
tendrils looping,
Coiled the lithe lianas fold on fold,
Or, in cataracts of verdure drooping,
From on high their billowy leafage
rolled.

Where beneath the dusky woodland
cover,
While the noon-hush holds all
living things,
Butterflies of tropic splendour hover
In a maze of rainbow-coloured
wings:
Some like stars light up their own
green heaven
Some are spangled like a golden
toy,
Or like flowers from their foliage
driven
In the fiery ecstasy of joy.

But, the forest slumber rudely
breaking,
Through the silence rings a
piercing yell;
At the cry unnumbered beasts,
awaking,
With their howls the loud
confusion swell.

'Tis the cry of some frail creature
panting
In the tiger's lacerating grip;
In its flesh carnivorous teeth
implanting,
While the blood smokes round his
wrinkled lip.

'Tis the scream some bird in terror
utters,
With its wings weighed down by
leaden fears,
As from bough to downward bough it
flutters
Where the snake its glistening crest
uprears:
Eyes of sluggish greed through rank
weeds stealing,
Breath whose venomous fumes
mount through the air,
Till benumbed the helpless victim,
reeling,
Drops convulsed into the reptile
snare.

Now we fared o'er sweltering wastes
whose steaming
Clouds of tawny sand the wanderer
blind.
Herds of horses with their long manes
streaming
Snorted thirstily against the wind;
O'er the waste they scoured in
shadowy numbers,
Gasp'd for springs their raging
thirst to cool,

And, like sick men mocked in fevered
slumbers,
Stoop to drink—and find a
phantom pool.

What of antelopes crunched by the
leopard?
What if hounds run down the timid
hare?
What though sheep, strayed from the
faithful shepherd,
Perish helpless in the lion's lair?
The all-seeing sun shines on
unheeding,
In the night shines the unruffled
moon,
Though on earth brute myriads,
preying, bleeding,
Put creation harshly out of tune.

Cried I, turning to the shrouded figure

—
"Oh, in mercy veil this cruel strife!
Sanguinary orgies which disfigure
The green ways of labyrinthine
life.
From the needs and greeds of primal
passion,
From the serpent's track and lion's
den,
To the world our human hands did
fashion,
Lead me to the kindly haunts of
men."

And through fields of corn we passed
together,

Orange golden in the brooding
heat,
Where brown reapers in the harvest
weather
Cut ripe swathes of downward
rustling wheat.
In the orchards dangling red and
yellow,
Clustered fruit weighed down the
bending sprays;
On a hundred hills the vines grew
mellow
In the warmth of fostering autumn
days.

Through the air the shrilly twittering
swallows
Flashed their nimble shadows on
the leas;
Red-flecked cows were glassed in
golden shallows,
Purple clover hummed with
restless bees.
Herdsmen drove the cattle from the
mountain,
To the fold the shepherd drove his
flocks,
Village girls drew water from the
fountain,
Village yokels piled the full-eared
shocks.

From the white town dozing in the
valley,
Round its vast Cathedral's solemn
shade,

Citizens strolled down the walnut
alley
Where youth courted and glad
childhood played.
"Peace on earth," I murmured; "let us
linger—
Here the wage of life seems good
at least."
As I spake the veiled One raised a
finger
Where the moon broke flowering
in the east.

Faintly muttering from deep
mountain ranges,
Muffled sounds rose hoarsely on
the night,
As the crash of foundering
avalanches
Wakes hoarse echoes in each
Alpine height.
Near and nearer sounds the roaring—
thunder,
Mortal thunder, crashes through the
vale;
Lightning flash of muskets breaks
from under
Groves once haunted by the
nightingale.

Men clutch madly at each weapon—
women,
Children crouch in cellars, under
roofs,
For the town is circled by their
foemen—

Shakes the ground with clang of
trampling hoofs.
Shot on shot the volleys hiss and
rattle,
Shrilly whistling fly the murderous
balls,
Fiercely roars the tumult of the battle
Round the hard-contested, dear-
bought walls.

Horror, horror! The fair town is
burning,
Flames burst forth, wild sparks and
ashes fly;
With her children's blood the green
earth's turning
Blood-red—blood-red, too, the
cloud-winged sky.
Crackling flare the streets: from the
lone steeple
The great clock booms forth its
ancient chime,
And its dolorous quarters warn the
people
Of the conquering troops that
march with time.

Fallen lies the fair old town, its
houses
Charred and ruined gape in
smoking heaps;
Here with shouts a ruffian band
carouses,
There an outraged woman vainly
weeps.
In the fields where the ripe corn lies
mangled,

Where the wounded groan beneath
the dead,
Friend and foe, now helplessly
entangled,
Stain red poppies with a guiltier
red.

There the dog howls o'er his perished
master,
There the crow comes circling
from afar;
All vile things that batten on disaster
Follow feasting in the wake of war.
Famine follows—what they ploughed
and planted
The unhappy peasants shall not
reap;
Sickening of strange meats and fever
haunted,
To their graves they prematurely
creep.

"Hence"—I cried in unavailing pity—
"Let us flee these scenes of
monstrous strife,
Seek the pale of some imperial city
Where the law rules starlike o'er
man's life."
Straightway floating o'er blue sea and
river,
We were plunged into a roaring
cloud,
Wherethrough lamps in ague fits did
shiver
O'er the surging multitudinous
crowd.

Piles of stone, their cliff-like walls
 uprearing,
 Flashed in luminous lines along the
 night;
Jets of flame, spasmodically flaring,
 Splashed black pavements with a
 sickly light;
Fabulous gems shone here, and
 glowing coral,
 Shimmering stuffs from many an
 Eastern loom,
And vast piles of tropic fruits and
 floral
 Marvels seemed to mock
 November's gloom.

But what prowls near princely mart
 and dwelling,
 Whence through many a
 thundering thoroughfare
Rich folk roll on cushions softly
 swelling
 To the week-day feast and Sunday
 prayer?
Yea, who prowl there, hunger-nipped
 and pallid,
 Breathing nightmares limned upon
 the gloom?
'Tis but human rubbish, gaunt and
 squalid,
 Whom their country spurns for
 lack of room.

In their devious track we mutely
 follow,
 Mutely climb dim flights of oozy
 stairs,

Where through gap-toothed, mizzling
roof the yellow
Pestilent fog blends with the fetid
air.

Through the unhinged door's
discordant slamming
Ring the gruesome sounds of
savage strife—
Howls of babes, the drunken father's
damning,
Counter-cursing of the shrill-
tongued wife.

Children feebly crying on their
mother
In a wailful chorus—"Give us
food!"
Man and woman glaring at each other
Like two gaunt wolves with a
famished brood.
Till he snatched a stick, and, madly
staring,
Struck her blow on blow upon the
head;
And she, reeling back, gasped, hardly
caring—
"Ah, you've done it now, Jim"—
and was dead.

Dead—dead—dead—the miserable
creature—
Never to feel hunger's cruel fang
Wring the bowels of rebellious nature
That her infants might be spared
the pang.
"Dead! Good luck to her!" The man's
teeth chattered,

Stone-still stared he with blank
 eyes and hard,
Then, his frame with one big sob nigh
 shattered,
Fled—and cut his throat down in
 the yard.

Dark the night—the children wail
 forsaken,
 Crane their wrinkled necks and cry
 for food,
Drop off into fitful sleep, or waken
 Trembling like a sparrow's
 ravished brood.
Dark the night—the rain falls on the
 ashes,
 Feebly hissing on the feeble heat,
Filters through the ceiling, drops in
 splashes
 On the little children's naked feet.

Dark the night—the children wail
 forsaken—
 Is there none, ah, none, to heed
 their moan?
Yea, at dawn one little one is taken,
 Four poor souls are left, but one is
 gone.
Gone—escaped—flown from the
 shame and sorrow
 Waiting for them at life's sombre
 gate,
But the hand of merciless to-morrow
 Drags the others shuddering to
 their fate.

But one came—a girlish thing—a
creature
Flung by wanton hands 'mid lust
and crime—
A poor outcast, yet by right of nature
Sweet as odour of the upland
thyme.
Scapegoat of a people's sins, and
hunted,
Howled at, hooted to the
wilderness,
To that wilderness of deaf hearts,
blunted
To the depths of woman's dumb
distress.

Jetsam, flotsam of the monster city,
Spurned, defiled, reviled, that
outcast came
To those babes that whined for love
and pity,
Gave them bread bought with the
wage of shame.
Gave them bread, and gave them
warm, maternal
Kisses not on sale for any price:
Yea, a spark, a flash of some eternal
Sympathy shone through those
haunted eyes.

Ah, perchance through her dark life's
confusion,
Through the haste and taste of
fevered hours,
Gusts of memory on her youth's
pollution

Blew forgotten scents of faded
flowers.
And she saw the cottage near the wild
wood,
With its lichened roof and latticed
panes,
Strayed once more through golden
fields of childhood,
Hyacinth dells and hawthorn-
scented lanes.

Heard once more the song of nesting
thrushes
And the blackbird's long
mellifluous note,
Felt once more the glow of maiden
blushes
Burn through rosy cheek and
milkwhite throat
In that orchard where the apple
blossom
Lightly shaken fluttered on her
hair,
As the heart was fluttering in her
bosom
When her sweetheart came and
kissed her there.

Often came he in the lilac-laden
Moonlit twilight, often pledged his
word;
But she was a simple country-
maiden,
He the offspring of a noble lord.
Fading lilacs May's farewell betoken,
Fledglings fly and soon forget the
nest;

Lightly may a young man's vows be
 broken,
And the heart break in a woman's
 breast.

Gathered like a sprig of summer roses
 In the dewy morn and flung away,
To the girl the father's door now
 closes,
Let her shelter henceforth how she
 may.

Who will house the miserable mother
 With her child, a helpless
 castaway!

"I, am I the keeper of my brother?"
 Asks smug virtue as it turns to
 pray!

Lovely are the earliest Lenten lilies,
 Primrose pleiads, hyacinthine
 sheets;
Stripped and rifled from their pastoral
 valleys,
See them sold now in the public
 streets!
Other flowers are sold there besides
 posies—
Eyes may have the hyacinth's
 glowing blue,
Rounded cheeks the velvet bloom of
 roses,
Taper necks the rain-washed lily's
 hue.

But a rustic blossom! Love and duty
 Bound up in a child whom hunger
 slays!

Ah! but one thing still is left her—
 beauty
 Fresh, untarnished yet—and beauty
 pays.
Beauty keeps her child alive a little,
 Then it dies—her woman's love
 with it—
Beauty's brilliant sceptre, ah, how
 brittle,
 Drags her daily deeper down the
 pit.

Ruin closes o'er her—hideous,
 nameless;
 Each fresh morning marks a deeper
 fall;
Till at twenty—callous, cankered,
 shameless,
 She lies dying at the hospital.
Drink, more drink, she calls for—her
 harsh laughter
 Grates upon the meekly praying
 nurse,
Eloquent about her soul's hereafter:
 "Souls be blowed!" she sings out
 with a curse.

And so dies, an unrepenting sinner—
 Pitched into her pauper's grave
 what time
That most noble lord rides by to
 dinner
 Who had wooed her in her
 innocent prime.
And in after-dinner talk he preaches
 Resignation—o'er his burgundy—

Till a grateful public dubs his
speeches
Oracles of true philanthropy.

Peace ye call this? Call this justice,
meted
Equally to rich and poor alike?
Better than this peace the battle's
heated
Cannon-balls that ask not whom
they strike!
Better than this masquerade of culture
Hiding strange hyæna appetites,
The frank ravening of the raw-necked
vulture
As its beak the senseless carrion
smites.

What of men in bondage, toiling
blunted
In the roaring factory's lurid
gloom?
What of cradled infants starved and
stunted?
What of woman's nameless
martyrdom?
The all-seeing sun shines on
unheeding,
Shines by night the calm, unruffled
moon,
Though the human myriads, preying,
bleeding,
Put creation harshly out of tune.

"Hence, ah, hence"—I sobbed in
quivering passion—

"From these fearful haunts of
fiendish men!
Better far the plain, carnivorous
fashion
Which is practised in the lion's
den."
And I fled—yet staggering still did
follow
In the footprints of my shrouded
guide—
To the sea-caves echoing with the
hollow
Immemorial moaning of the tide.

Sinking, swelling roared the wintry
ocean,
Pitch-black chasms struck with
flying blaze,
As the cloud-winged storm-sky's
sheer commotion
Showed the blank Moon's mute
Medusa face
White o'er wastes of water—surges
crashing
Over surges in the formless gloom,
And a mastless hulk, with great seas
washing
Her scourged flanks, pitched
toppling to her doom.

Through the crash of wave on wave
gigantic,
Through the thunder of the
hurricane,
My wild heart in breaking shrilled
with frantic
Exultation—"Chaos come again!

Yea, let earth be split and cloven
asunder
With man's still accumulating curse

—

Life is but a momentary blunder
In the cycle of the Universe.

"Yea, let earth with forest-belted
mountains,
Hills and valleys, cataracts and
plains,
With her clouds and storms and fires
and fountains,
Pass with all her rolling sphere
contains,
Melt, dissolve again into the ocean,
Ocean fade into a nebulous haze!"
And I sank back without sense or
motion
'Neath the blank Moon's mute
Medusa face.

Moments, years, or ages passed,
when, lifting
Freezing lids, I felt the heavens on
high,
And, innumerable as the sea-sands
drifting,
Stars unnumbered drifted through
the sky.
Rhythmical in luminous rotation,
In dædalian maze they reel and fly,
And their rushing light is Time's
pulsation
In his passage through Eternity.

Constellated suns, fresh lit, declining,

Were ignited now, now quenched
in space,
Rolling round each other, or inclining
Orb to orb in multi-coloured rays.
Ever showering from their flaming
fountains
Light more light on each far-
circling earth,
Till life stirred crepuscular seas, and
mountains
Heaved convulsive with the throes
of birth.

And the noble brotherhood of planets,
Knitted each to each by links of
light,
Circled round their suns, nor knew a
minute's
Lapse or languor in their ceaseless
flight.
And pale moons and rings and
burning splinters
Of wrecked worlds swept round
their parent spheres,
Clothed with spring or sunk in polar
winters
As their sun draws nigh or
disappears.

Still new vistas of new stars—far
dwindling—
Through the firmament like
dewdrops roll,
Torches of the Cosmos which
enkindling
Flash their revelation on the soul.

Yea, One spake there—though nor
form nor feature
Shown—a Voice came from the
peaks of time:—
"Wilt thou judge me, wilt thou curse
me, Creature
Whom I raised up from the Ocean
slime?

"Long I waited—ages rolled o'er ages
—

As I crystallized in granite rocks,
Struggling dumb through immemorial
stages,
Glacial æons, fiery earthquake
shocks.
In fierce throbs of flame or slow
upheaval,
Speck by tiny speck, I topped the
seas,
Leaped from earth's dark womb, and
in primeval
Forests shot up shafts of mammoth
trees.

"Through a myriad forms I yearned
and panted,
Putting forth quick shoots in
endless swarms—
Giant-hoofed, sharp-tusked, or finned
or planted
Writhing on the reef with pinioned
arms.
I have climbed from reek of sanguine
revels
In Cimmerian wood and thorny
wild,

Slowly upwards to the dawnlit levels
Where I bore thee, oh my youngest
Child!

"Oh, my heir and hope of my to-
morrow,
I—I draw thee on through fume
and fret,
Croon to thee in pain and call through
sorrow,
Flowers and stars take for thy
alphabet.
Through the eyes of animals
appealing,
Feel my fettered spirit yearn to
thine,
Who, in storm of will and clash of
feeling,
Shape the life that shall be—the
divine.

"Oh, redeem me from my tiger rages,
Reptile greed, and foul hyæna lust;
With the hero's deeds, the thoughts of
sages,
Sow and fructify this passive dust;
Drop in dew and healing love of
woman
On the bloodstained hands of
hungry strife,
Till there break from passion of the
Human
Morning-glory of transfigured life.

"I have cast my burden on thy
shoulder;
Unimagined potencies have given

That from formless Chaos thou shalt
 mould her
And translate gross earth to
 luminous heaven.
Bear, oh, bear the terrible
 compulsion,
Flinch not from the path thy fathers
 trod,
From Man's martyrdom in slow
 convulsion
Will be born the infinite goodness
 —God."

Ceased the Voice: and as it ceased it
 drifted
Like the seashell's inarticulate
 moan;
From the Deep, on wings of flame
 uplifted,
Rose the sun rejoicing and alone.
Laughed in light upon the living
 ocean,
Danced and rocked itself upon the
 spray,
And its shivered beams in twinkling
 motion
Gleamed like star-motes of the
 Milky Way.

And beside me in the golden morning
 I beheld my shrouded phantom-
 guide;
But no longer sorrow-veiled and
 mourning—
It became transfigured by my side.
And I knew—as one escaped from
 prison

Sees old things again with fresh
surprise—
It was Love himself, Love re-arisen
With the Eternal shining through
his eyes.

POEMS OF THE OPEN AIR.

"Therefore all seasons shall be sweet
to thee,
Whether the summer clothe the
general earth
With greenness, or the redbreast sit
and sing
Betwixt the tufts of snow on the bare
branch."

S. T. COLERIDGE.

THE SOWER.

The winds had hushed at last as by
command;
The quiet sky above,
With its grey clouds spread o'er the
fallow land,
Sat brooding like a dove

There was no motion in the air, no
sound
Within the tree-tops stirred,
Save when some last leaf, fluttering
to the ground,
Dropped like a wounded bird:

Or when the swart rooks in a
gathering crowd
With clamorous noises wheeled,
Hovering awhile, then swooped with
wranglings loud
Down on the stubbly field.

For now the big-thewed horses,
toiling slow

In straining couples yoked,
Patiently dragged the ploughshare to
and fro
Till their wet haunches smoked.

Till the stiff acre, broken into clods,
Bruised by the harrow's tooth,
Lay lightly shaken, with its humid
sods
Ranged into furrows smooth.

There looming lone, from rise to set
of sun,
Without or pause or speed,
Solemnly striding by the furrows dun,
The sower sows the seed.

The sower sows the seed, which
mouldering,
Deep coffined in the earth,
Is buried now, but with the future
spring
Will quicken into birth.

Oh, poles of birth and death!
Controlling Powers
Of human toil and need!
On this fair earth all men are surely
sowers,
Surely all life is seed!

All life is seed, dropped in Time's
yawning furrow,
Which with slow sprout and
shoot,
In the revolving world's unfathomed
morrow,
Will blossom and bear fruit.

A SPRING SONG.

Dark sod pierced by flames of
 flowers,
 Dead wood freshly quickening,
Bright skies dusked with sudden
 showers,
 Lit by rainbows on the wing.

Cuckoo calls and young lambs'
 bleating
 Nimble airs which coyly bring
Little gusts of tender greeting
 From shy nooks where violets
 cling.

Half-fledged buds and birds and
 vernal
 Fields of grass dew-glistening;
Evanescent life's eternal
 Resurrection, bridal Spring!

APRIL RAIN.

The April rain, the April rain,
Comes slanting down in fitful
 showers,
 Then from the furrow shoots the
 grain,
And banks are fledged with nestling
 flowers;
And in grey shaw and woodland
 bowers
 The cuckoo through the April rain

Calls once again.

The April sun, the April sun,
Glints through the rain in fitful
splendour,
And in grey shaw and woodland
dun
The little leaves spring forth and
tender
Their infant hands, yet weak and
slender,
For warmth towards the April sun,
One after one.

And between shower and shine
hath birth
The rainbow's evanescent glory;
Heaven's light that breaks on mists
of earth!
Frail symbol of our human story,
It flowers through showers where,
looming hoary,
The rain-clouds flash with April
mirth,
Like Life on earth.

THE SLEEPING BEAUTY.

There was intoxication in the air;
The wind, keen blowing from
across the seas,
O'er leagues of new-ploughed land
and heathery leas,
Smelt of wild gorse whose gold
flamed everywhere.

An undertone of song pulsed far and
near,
The soaring larks filled heaven
with ecstasies,
And, like a living clock among the
trees,
The shouting cuckoo struck the time
of year.

For now the Sun had found the earth
once more,
And woke the Sleeping Beauty
with a kiss;
Who thrilled with light of love in
every pore,
Opened her flower-blue eyes, and
looked in his.
Then all things felt life fluttering at
their core—
The world shook mystical in
lambent bliss.

APPLE-BLOSSOM.

Blossom of the apple trees!
Mossy trunks all gnarled and
hoary,
Grey boughs tipped with rose-
veined glory,
Clustered petals soft as fleece
Garlanding old apple trees!

How you gleam at break of day!
When the coy sun, glancing rarely,
Pouts and sparkles in the pearly
Pendulous dewdrops, twinkling gay

On each dancing leaf and spray.

Through your latticed boughs on
 high,
 Framed in rosy wreaths, one
 catches
 Brief kaleidoscopic snatches
Of deep lapis-lazuli
In the April-coloured sky.

When the sundown's dying brand
 Leaves your beauty to the tender
 Magic spells of moonlight
 splendour,
Glimmering clouds of bloom you
 stand,
Turning earth to fairyland.

Cease, wild winds, O, cease to blow!
 Apple-blossom, fluttering, flying,
 Palely on the green turf lying,
Vanishing like winter snow;
Swift as joy to come and go.

THE MUSIC-LESSON.

A thrush alit on a young-leaved spray,
 And, lightly clinging,
 It rocked in its singing
As the rapturous notes rose loud and
 gay;
 And with liquid shakes,
 And trills and breaks,
Rippled through blossoming boughs
 of May.

Like a ball of fluff, with a warm
brown throat
And throbbing bosom,
'Mid the apple-blossom,
The new-fledged nestling sat learning
by rote
To echo the song
So tender and strong,
As it feebly put in its frail little note.

O blisfullest lesson amid the green
grove!
The low wind crispeth
The leaves, where lispeth
The shy little bird with its parent
above;
Two voices that mingle
And make but a single
Hymn of rejoicing in praise of their
love.

THE TEAMSTER.

With slow and slouching gait Sam
leads the team;
He stoops i' the shoulders, worn
with work not years;
One only passion has he, it would
seem—
The passion for the horses which
he rears:
He names them as one would some
household pet,
May, Violet.

He thinks them quite as sensible as
men;
As nice as women, but not near so
skittish;
He fondles, cossets, scolds them now
and then,
Nay, gravely talks as if they knew
good British:
You hear him call from dawn to set of
sun,
"Goo back! Com on!"

Sam never seems depressed nor yet
elate,
Like Nature's self he goes his
punctual round;
On Sundays, smoking by his garden
gate,
For hours he'll stand, with eyes
upon the ground,
Like some tired cart-horse in a field
alone,
And still as stone.

Yet, howsoever stolid he may seem,
Sam has his tragic background,
weird and wild
Like some adventure in a drunkard's
dream.
Impossible, you'd swear, for one so
mild:
Yet village gossips dawdling o'er
their ale
Still tell the tale.

In his young days Sam loved a
servant-maid,

A girl with happy eyes like hazel
 brooks
That dance i' the sun, cheeks as if
 newly made
Of pouting roses coyly hid in
 nooks,
And warm brown hair that wantoned
 into curl:
 A fresh-blown girl.

Sam came a-courting while the year
 was blithe,
When wet browed mowers,
 stepping out in tune,
With level stroke and rhythmic swing
 of scythe,
Smote down the proud grass in the
 pomp of June,
And wagons, half-tipped over,
 seemed to sway
 With loads of hay.

The elder bush beside the orchard
 croft
Brimmed over with its bloom like
 curds and cream;
From out grey nests high in the
 granary loft
Black clusters of small heads with
 callow scream
Peered open-beaked, as swallows
 flashed along
 To feed their young.

Ripening towards the harvest swelled
 the wheat,

Lush cherries dangled 'gainst the
latticed panes;
The roads were baking in the
windless heat,
And dust had floured the glossy
country lanes,
One sun-hushed, light-flushed
Sunday afternoon
The last of June.

When, with his thumping heart all out
of joint,
And pulses beating like a stroller's
drum,
Sam screwed his courage to the
sticking point
And asked his blushing sweetheart
if she'd come
To Titsey Fair; he meant to coax coy
May
To name the day.

But her rich master snapped his
thumb and swore
The girl was not for him! Should
not go out!
And, whistling to his dogs, slammed-
to the door
Close in Sam's face, and left him
dazed without
In the fierce sunshine, blazing in his
path
Like fire of wrath.

Unheeding, he went forth with hot
wild eyes

Past fields of feathery oats and
 wine-red clover;
Unheeded, larks soared singing to the
 skies,
Or rang the plaintive cry of rising
 plover;
Unheeded, pheasants with a startled
 sound
 Whirred from the ground.

On, on he went by acres full of grain,
 By trees and meadows reeling past
 his sight,
As to a man whirled onwards in a
 train
 The land with spinning hedgerows
 seems in flight;
At last he stopped and leant a long,
 long while
 Against a stile.

Hours passed; the clock struck ten; a
 hush of night,
 In which even wind and water
 seemed at peace;
But here and there a glimmering
 cottage light
 Shone like a glowworm through
 the slumberous trees;
Or from some far-off homestead
 through the dark
 A watch-dog's bark.

But all at once Sam gave a stifled cry:
 "There's fire," he muttered, "fire
 upon the hills!"

No fire—but as the late moon rose on
high
Her light looked smoke-red as
through belching mills:
No fire—but moonlight turning in his
path
To fire of wrath.

He looked abroad with eyes that gave
the mist
A lurid tinge above the breadths of
grain
Owned by May's master. Then he
shook his fist,
Still muttering, "Fire!" and
measured o'er again
The road he'd come, where, lapped in
moonlight, lay
Huge ricks of hay.

There he paused glaring. Then he
turned and waned
Like mist into the misty, moon-
soaked night,
Where the pale silvery fields were
blotched and stained
With strange fantastic shadows.
But what light
Is that which leaps up, flickering lithe
and long,
With licking tongue!

Hungry it darts and hisses, twists and
turns,
And with each minute shoots up
high and higher,

Till, wrapped in flames, the mighty
 hayrick burns
And sends its sparks on to a
 neighbouring byre,
Where, frightened at the hot,
 tremendous glow,
 The cattle low.

And rick on rick takes fire; and next a
 stye,
 Whence through the smoke the
 little pigs rush out;
The house-dog barks; then, with a
 startled cry,
 The window is flung open, shout
 on shout
Wakes the hard-sleeping farm where
 man and maid
 Start up dismayed.

And with wild faces wavering in the
 glare,
 In nightcaps, bedgowns, clothes
 half huddled on
Some to the pump, some to the duck-
 pond tear
 In frantic haste, while others
 splashing run
With pails, or turn the hose with
 flame-scorched face
 Upon the blaze.

At last, when some wan streaks began
 to show
 In the chill darkness of the sky, the
 fire

Went out, subdued but for the
 sputtering glow
Of sparks among wet ashes. Barn
 and byre
Were safe, but swallowed all the
 summer math
 By fire of wrath.

Still haggard from the night's wild
 work and pale,
Farm-men and women stood in
 whispering knots,
Regaled with foaming mugs of nut-
 brown ale;
Firing his oaths about like vicious
 shots,
The farmer hissed out now and then:
 "Gad damn!
 It's that black Sam."

They had him up and taxed him with
 the crime;
Denying naught, he sulked and
 held his peace;
And so, a branded convict, in due
 time,
Handcuffed and cropped, they
 shipped him over-seas:
Seven years of shame sliced from his
 labourer's life
 As with a knife.

But through it all the image of a girl
 With hazel eyes like pebbled
 waters clear,
And warm brown hair that wantoned
 into curl,

Kept his heart sweet through many
a galling year,
Like to a bit of lavender long pressed
In some black chest.

At last his time was up, and Sam
returned
To his dear village with its single
street,
Where, in the sooty forge, the fire
still burned,
As, hammering on the anvil, red
with heat,
The smith wrought at a shoe with
tongues aglow,
Blow upon blow.

There stood the church, with peals for
death and birth,
Its ancient spire o'ertopping ancient
trees,
And there the graves and mounds of
unknown earth,
Gathered like little children round
its knees;
There was "The Bull," with sign
above the door,
And sanded floor.

Unrecognized Sam took his glass of
beer,
And picked up gossip which the
men let fall:
How Farmer Clow had failed, and
one named Steer
Had taken on the land, repairs and
all;

And how the Kimber girl was to be
wed
To Betsy's Ned.

Sam heard no more, flung down his
pence, and took
The way down to the well-
remembered stile;
There, in the gloaming by the trysting
brook,
He came upon his May—with just
that smile
For sheep-faced Ned, that light in
happy eyes:
Oh, sugared lies!

He came upon them with black-
knitted brows
And clenched brown hands, and
muttered huskily:
"Oh, little May, are those your true
love's vows
You swore to keep while I was
over-sea?"
Then crying, turned upon the other
one,
"Com on, com on."

Then they fell to with faces set for
fight,
And hit each other hard with rustic
pride;
But Sam, whose arm with iron force
could smite,
Knocked his cowed rival down,
and won his bride.

May wept and smiled, swayed like a
wild red rose
As the wind blows.

She married Sam, who loved her with
a wild
Strong love he could not put to
words—too deep
For her to gauge; but with her first-
born child
May dropped off, flower-like, into
the long sleep,
And left him nothing but the memory
of
His little love.

Since then the silent teamster lives
alone,
The trusted headman of his master
Steer;
One only passion seems he still to
own—
The passion for the foals he has to
rear;
And still the prettiest, full of life and
play,
Is little May.

A HIGHLAND VILLAGE.

Clear shining after the rain,
The sun bursts the clouds asunder,
And the hollow-rumbling thunder
Groans like a loaded wain
As, deep in the Grampians yonder,
He grumbles now and again.

Whenever the breezes shiver
The leaves where the rain-drops
 quiver,
 Each bough and bush and brier
 Breaks into living fire,
Till every tree is bright
With blossom bursts of light.

From golden roof and spout
 Brown waters gurgle and splutter,
 And rush down the flooded gutter
Where the village children shout,
As barefoot they splash in and out
 The water with tireless patter.

The bald little Highland street
 Is all alive and a-glitter;
The air blows keen and sweet
 From the field where the swallows
 twitter;
Old wives on the doorsteps meet,
 At the corner the young maids
 titter.

And the reapers hasten again,
Ere quite the daylight wane
 To shake out the barley sheaves;
 While through the twinkling leaves
 The harvest moon upheaves
Clear shining after the rain.

ON A FORSAKEN LARK'S NEST.

Lo, where left 'mid the sheaves, cut down by the
 iron-fanged reaper,

Eating its way as it clangs fast through the wavering
wheat,
Lies the nest of a lark, whose little brown eggs could
not keep her
As she, affrighted and scared, fled from the
harvester's feet.

Ah, what a heartfelt of song that now will never
awaken,
Closely packed in the shell, awaited love's fostering,
That should have quickened to life what, now a-cold
and forsaken,
Never, enamoured of light, will meet the dawn on the
wing.

Ah, what pæans of joy, what raptures no mortal can
measure,
Sweet as honey that's sealed in the cells of the
honey-comb,
Would have ascended on high in jets of mellifluous
pleasure,
Would have dropped from the clouds to nest in its
gold-curtained home.

Poor, pathetic brown eggs! Oh, pulses that never will
quicken!
Music mute in the shell that hath been turned to a
tomb!
Many a sweet human singer, chilled and adversity-
stricken,
Withers benumbed in a world his joy might have
helped to illumine.

REAPERS.

Sun-tanned men and women, toiling
there together;
Seven I count in all, in yon field of
wheat,
Where the rich ripe ears in the harvest
weather
Glow an orange gold through the
sweltering heat.

Busy life is still, sunk in brooding
leisure:
Birds have hushed their singing in
the hushed tree-tops;
Not a single cloud mars the flawless
azure;
Not a shadow moves o'er the
moveless crops;

In the glassy shallows, that no breath
is creasing,
Chestnut-coloured cows in the
rushes dank
Stand like cows of bronze, save when
they flick the teasing
Flies with switch of tail from each
quivering flank.

Nature takes a rest—even her bees
are sleeping,
And the silent wood seems a
church that's shut;
But these human creatures cease not
from their reaping
While the corn stands high, waiting
to be cut.

APPLE-GATHERING.

Essex flats are pink with clover,
Kent is crowned with flaunting
hops,
Whitely shine the cliffs of Dover,
Yellow wave the Midland crops;

Sussex Downs the flocks grow sleek
on,
But, for me, I love to stand
Where the Herefordshire beacon
Watches o'er his orchard land.

Where now sun, now shadow dapples
—
As it wavers in the breeze—
Clumps of fresh-complexioned apples
On the heavy-laden trees:

Red and yellow, streaked and hoary,
Russet-coated, pale or brown—
Some are dipped in sunset glory,
And some painted by the dawn.

What profusion, what abundance!
Not a twig but has its fruits;
High in air some in the sun dance,
Some lie scattered near the roots.

These the hasty winds have taken
Are a green, untimely crop;
Those by burly rustics shaken
Fall with loud resounding plop.

In this mellow autumn weather,
Ruddy 'mid the long green grass,
Heaped-up baskets stand together,

Filled by many a blowsy lass.

Red and yellow, streaked and hoary,
Pile them on the granary floors,
Till the yule-log's flame in glory
Loudly up the chimney roars;

Till gay troops of children, lightly
Tripping in with shouts of glee,
See ripe apples dangling brightly
On the red-lit Christmas-tree.

THE SONGS OF SUMMER.

The songs of summer are over and
past!
The swallow's forsaken the
dripping eaves;
Ruined and black 'mid the sodden
leaves
The nests are rudely swung in the
blast:
And ever the wind like a soul in
pain
Knocks and knocks at the window-
pane.

The songs of summer are over and
past!
Woe's me for a music sweeter than
theirs—
The quick, light bound of a step on
the stairs,
The greeting of lovers too sweet to
last:

And ever the wind like a soul in
 pain
Knocks and knocks at the window-
 pane.

AUTUMN TINTS.

Coral-coloured yew-berries
 Strew the garden ways,
Hollyhocks and sunflowers
 Make a dazzling blaze
In these latter days.

Marigolds by cottage doors
 Flaunt their golden pride,
Crimson-punctured bramble leaves
 Dapple far and wide
The green mountain-side.

Far away, on hilly slopes
 Where fleet rivulets run,
Miles on miles of tangled fern,
 Burnished by the sun,
Glow a copper dun.

For the year that's on the wane,
 Gathering all its fire,
Flares up through the kindling world
 As, ere they expire,
Flames leap high and higher.

GREEN LEAVES AND SERE.

Three tall poplars beside the pool
 Shiver and moan in the gusty blast,

The carded clouds are blown like
 wool,
And the yellowing leaves fly thick
 and fast.

The leaves, now driven before the
 blast,
Now flung by fits on the curdling
 pool,
Are tossed heaven-high and dropped
 at last
As if at the whim of a jabbering
 fool.

O leaves, once rustling green and
 cool!
Two met here where one moans
 aghast
With wild heart heaving towards the
 past:
Three tall poplars beside the pool.

THE HUNTER'S MOON.

The Hunter's Moon rides high,
 High o'er the close-cropped plain;
Across the desert sky
 The herded clouds amain
Scamper tumultuously,
 Chased by the hounding wind
 That yelps behind.

The clamorous hunt is done,
 Warm-housed the kennelled pack;
One huntsman rides alone
 With dangling bridle slack;

He wakes a hollow tone,
Far echoing to his horn
In clefts forlorn.

The Hunter's Moon rides low,
Her course is nearly sped.
Where is the panting roe?
Where hath the wild deer fled?
Hunter and hunted now
Lie in oblivion deep:
Dead or asleep.

THE PASSING YEAR.

No breath of wind stirs in the painted
leaves,
The meadows are as stirless as the
sky,
Like a Saint's halo golden vapours
lie
Above the restful valley's garnered
sheaves.
The journeying Sun, like one who
fondly grieves,
Above the hills seems loitering
with a sigh,
As loth to bid the fruitful earth
good-bye,
On these hushed hours of luminous
autumn eves.

There is a pathos in his softening
glow,
Which like a benediction seems to
hover

O'er the tranced earth, ere he must
 sink below
And leave her widowed of her
 radiant Lover,
A frost-bound sleeper in a shroud of
 snow
While winter winds howl a wild
 dirge above her.

THE ROBIN REDBREAST.

The year's grown songless! No glad
 pipings thrill
The hedge-row elms, whose wind-
 worn branches shower
Their leaves on the sere grass,
 where some late flower
In golden chalice hoards the sunlight
 still.
Our summer guests, whose raptures
 used to fill
Each apple-blossomed garth and
 honeyed bower,
Have in adversity's inclement hour
Abandoned us to bleak November's
 chill.

But hearken! Yonder russet bird
 among
The crimson clusters of the homely
 thorn
Still bubbles o'er with little rills of
 song—
A blending of sweet hope and
 resignation:

Even so, when life of love and
youth is shorn,
One friend becomes its last, best
consolation.

THE RED SUNSETS, 1883.

The boding sky was characterized with
cloud,
The scripture of the storm—but
high in air,
Where the unfathomed zenith still
was bare,
A pure expanse of rose-flushed violet
glowed
And, kindling into crimson light,
o'erflowed
The hurrying wrack with such a
blood-red glare,
That heaven, igniting, wildly
seemed to flare
On the dazed eyes of many an awe-
struck crowd.

And in far lands folk presaged with
blanched lips
Disastrous wars, earthquakes, and
foundering ships
Such whelming floods as never
dykes could stem,
Or some proud empire's ruin and
eclipse:
Lo, such a sky, they cried, as
burned o'er them
Once lit the sacking of Jerusalem!

THE RED SUNSETS, 1883.

The twilight heavens are flushed with
 gathering light,
And o'er wet roofs and huddling
 streets below
Hang with a strange Apocalyptic
 glow
On the black fringes of the wintry
 night.
Such bursts of glory may have rapt
 the sight
Of him to whom on Patmos long
 ago
The visionary angel came to show
That heavenly city built of chrysolite.

And lo, three factory hands begrimed
 with soot,
Aflame with the red splendour,
 marvelling stand,
And gaze with lifted faces awed and
 mute.
Starved of earth's beauty by Man's
 grudging hand,
O toilers, robbed of labour's golden
 fruit,
Ye, too, may feast in Nature's
 fairyland.

ON THE LIGHTHOUSE AT ANTIBES.

A stormy light of sunset glows and
 glares

Between two banks of cloud, and
o'er the brine
Thy fair lamp on the sky's
carnation line
Alone on the lone promontory flares:
Friend of the Fisher who at nightfall
fares
Where lurk false reefs masked by
the hyaline
Of dimpling waves, within whose
smile divine
Death lies in wait behind Circean
snares.

The evening knows thee ere the
evening star;
Or sees thy flame sole Regent of
the bight,
When storm, hoarse rumoured by the
hills afar,
Makes mariners steer landward by
thy light,
Which shows through shock of
hostile nature's war
How man keeps watch o'er man
through deadliest night.

CAGNES.
ON THE RIVIERA.

In tortuous windings up the steep
incline
The sombre street toils to the
village square,
Whose antique walls in stone and
moulding bear

Dumb witness to the Moor. Afar off
shine,
With tier on tier, cutting heaven's blue
divine,
The snowy Alps; and lower the
hills are fair,
With wave-green olives rippling
down to where
Gold clusters hang and leaves of
sunburnt vine.

You may perchance, I never shall
forget
When, between twofold glory of
land and sea,
We leant together o'er the old parapet,
And saw the sun go down. For, oh,
to me,
The beauty of that beautiful strange
place
Was its reflection beaming from your
face.

A WINTER LANDSCAPE.

All night, all day, in dizzy, downward
flight,
Fell the wild-whirling, vague,
chaotic snow,
Till every landmark of the earth
below,
Trees, moorlands, roads, and each
familiar sight
Were blotted out by the bewildering
white.

And winds, now shrieking loud,
 now whimpering low,
Seemed lamentations for the
 world-old woe
That death must swallow life, and
 darkness light.

But all at once the rack was blown
 away,
The snowstorm hushing ended in a
 sigh;
Then like a flame the crescent
 moon on high
Leaped forth among the planets; pure
 as they,
Earth vied in whiteness with the
 Milky Way:
Herself a star beneath the starry
 sky.

LOVE IN EXILE.

"Whatever way my days decline,
I felt and feel, tho' left alone,
His being working in mine own,
The footsteps of his life in mine."

LORD TENNYSON.

SONGS.

I.

Thou walkest with me as the spirit-
light
Of the hushed moon, high o'er a
snowy hill,
Walks with the houseless traveller all
the night,
When trees are tongueless and
when mute the rill.
Moon of my soul, O phantasm of
delight,
Thou walkest with me still.

The vestal flame of quenchless
memory burns
In my soul's sanctuary. Yea, still for
thee
My bitter heart hath yearned, as
moonward yearns

Each separate wave-pulse of the
clamorous sea:
My Moon of love, to whom for ever
turns
The life that aches through me.

II.

I was again beside my Love in dream:
Earth was so beautiful, the moon
was shining;
The muffled voice of many a cataract
stream
Came like a love-song, as, with
arms entwining,
Our hearts were mixed in unison
supreme.

The wind lay spell-bound in each
pillared pine,
The tasselled larches had no sound
or motion,
As my whole life was sinking into
thine—
Sinking into a deep, unfathomed
ocean
Of infinite love—uncircumscribed,
divine.

Night held her breath, it seemed, with
all her stars:
Eternal eyes that watched in mute
compassion
Our little lives o'erleap their mortal
bars,

Fused in the fulness of immortal
passion,
A passion as immortal as the stars.

There was no longer any thee or me;
No sense of self, no wish or
incompleteness;
The moment, rounded to Eternity,
Annihilated time's destructive
fleetness:
For all but love itself had ceased to
be.

III.

I am athirst, but not for wine;
The drink I long for is divine,
Poured only from your eyes in mine.

I hunger, but the bread I want,
Of which my blood and brain are
scant,
Is your sweet speech, for which I
pant.

I am a-cold, and lagging lame,
Life creeps along my languid frame;
Your love would fan it into flame.

Heaven's in that little word—your
love!
It makes my heart coo like a dove,
My tears fall as I think thereof.

IV.

I would I were the glow-worm, thou
the flower,
That I might fill thy cup with
glimmering light;
I would I were the bird, and thou the
bower,
To sing thee songs throughout the
summer night.

I would I were a pine tree deeply
rooted,
And thou the lofty, cloud-
beleaguered rock,
Still, while the blasts of heaven
around us hooted,
To cleave to thee and weather
every shock.

I would I were the rill, and thou the
river;
So might I, leaping from some
headlong steep,
With all my waters lost in thine for
ever,
Be hurried onwards to the
unfathomed deep.

I would—what would I not? O
foolish dreaming!
My words are but as leaves by
autumn shed,
That, in the faded moonlight idly
gleaming,
Drop on the grave where all our
love lies dead.

V.

Dost thou remember ever, for my
 sake,
When we two rowed upon the rock-
 bound lake?
How the wind-fretted waters blew
 their spray
About our brows like blossom-falls of
 May
 One memorable day?

Dost thou remember the glad mouth
 that cried—
"Were it not sweet to die now side by
 side,
To lie together tangled in the deep
Close as the heart-beat to the heart—
 so keep
 The everlasting sleep?"

Dost thou remember? Ah, such death
 as this
Had set the seal upon my heart's
 young bliss!
But, wrenched asunder, severed and
 apart,
Life knew a deadlier death: the
 blighting smart
 Which only kills the heart.

VI.

O moon, large golden summer moon,
 Hanging between the linden trees,
 Which in the intermittent breeze

Beat with the rhythmic pulse of June!

O night-air, scented through and
through
With honey-coloured flower of
lime,
Sweet now as in that other time
When all my heart was sweet as you!

The sorcery of this breathing bloom
Works like enchantment in my
brain,
Till, shuddering back to life again,
My dead self rises from its tomb.

And, lovely with the love of yore,
Its white ghost haunts the moon-
white ways;
But, when it meets me face to face,
Flies trembling to the grave once
more.

VII.

Why will you haunt me unawares,
And walk into my sleep,
Pacing its shadowy thoroughfares,
Where long-dried perfume scents the
airs,
While ghosts of sorrow creep,
Where on Hope's ruined altar-stairs,
With ineffectual beams,
The Moon of Memory coldly glares
Upon the land of dreams?

My yearning eyes were fain to look

Upon your hidden face;
Their love, alas! you could not brook,
But in your own you mutely took
My hand, and for a space
You wrung it till I throbbed and
shook,
And woke with wildest moan
And wet face channelled like a brook
With your tears or my own.

VIII.

When you wake from troubled
slumbers
With a dream-bewildered brain,
And old leaves which no man
numbers
Chattering tap against the pane;
And the midnight wind is wailing
Till your very life seems quailing
As the long gusts shudder and sigh:
Know you not that homeless cry
Is my love's, which cannot die,
Wailing through Eternity?

When beside the glowing embers,
Sitting in the twilight lone,
Drop on drop you hear November's
Melancholy monotone,
As the heavy rain comes sweeping,
With a sound of weeping, weeping,
Till your blood is chilled with
fears;
Know you not those falling tears,
Flowing fast through years on
years,

For my sobs within your ears?

When with dolorous moan the
billows

Surge around where, far and wide,
Leagues on leagues of sea-worn
hollows

Throb with thunders of the tide,
And the weary waves in breaking
Fill you, thrill you, as with aching
Memories of our love of yore
Where you pace the sounding
shore,

Hear you not, through roll and roar,
Soul call soul for evermore?

IX.

In a lonesome burial-place
Crouched a mourner white of face;
Wild her eyes—unheeding
Circling pomp of night and day—
Ever crying, "Well away,
Love lies a-bleeding!"

And her sighs were like a knell,
And her tears for ever fell,
With their warm rain feeding
That purpureal flower, alas!
Trailing prostrate in the grass,
Love lies a-bleeding.

Through the yews' black-tufted
gloom
Crimson light dripped on the tomb,
Funeral shadows breeding:

In the sky the sun's light shed
Dyed the earth one awful red—
Love lies a-bleeding.

Came grey mists, and blanching
cloud
Bore one universal shroud;
Came the bowed moon leading,
From the infinite afar
Star that rumoured unto star—
Love lies a-bleeding.

X.

On life's long round by chance I
found
A dell impearled with dew,
Where hyacinths, gushing from the
ground,
Lent to the earth heaven's native
hue
Of holy blue.

I sought that plot of azure light
Once more in gloomy hours;
But snow had fallen overnight
And wrapped in mortuary white
My fairy ring of flowers.

XI.

Ah, yesterday was dark and drear,
My heart was deadly sore;
Without thy love it seemed, my Dear,
That I could live no more.

And yet I laugh and sing to-day;
Care or care not for me,
Thou canst not take the love away
With which I worship thee.

And if to-morrow, Dear, I live,
My heart I shall not break:
For still I hold it that to give
Is sweeter than to take.

XII.

Yea, the roses are still on fire
With the bygone heat of July,
Though the least little wind drifting
by
Shake a rose-leaf or two from the
brier,
Be it never so soft a sigh.

Ember of love still glows and lingers
Deep at the red heart's smouldering
core;
With the sudden passionate throb
of yore
We shook as our eyes and clinging
fingers
Met once only to meet no more.

XIII.

We met as strangers on life's lonely
way,
And yet it seemed we knew each
other well;

There was no end to what thou hadst
to say,
Or to the thousand things I found
to tell.
My heart, long silent, at thy voice that
day
Chimed in my breast like to a
silver bell.

How much we spoke, and yet still left
untold
Some secret half revealed within
our eyes:
Didst thou not love me once in ages
old?
Had I not called thee with
importunate cries,
And, like a child left sobbing in the
cold,
Listened to catch from far thy fond
replies?

We met as strangers, and as such we
part;
Yet all my life seems leaving me
with thine;
Ah, to be clasped once only heart to
heart,
If only once to feel that thou wert
mine!
These lips are locked, and yet I know
thou art
That all in all for which my soul
did pine.

You make the sunshine of my heart
And its tempestuous shower;
Sometimes the thought of you is like
A lilac bush in flower,
Yea, honey-sweet as hives in May.
And then the pang of it will strike
My bosom with a fiery smart,
As though love's deeply planted dart
Drained all its life away.

My thoughts hum round you, Dear,
like bees
About a bank of thyme,
Or round the yellow blossoms of
The heavy-scented lime.
Ah, sweeter you than honeydew,
Yet dark the ways of love,
For it has robbed my soul of peace,
And marred my life and turned
heart's-ease
Into funereal rue.

XV.

Dear, when I look into your eyes
My hurts are healed, my heart
grows whole;
The barren places in my soul,
Like waste lands under April skies,
Break into flower beneath your eyes.

Ah, life grows lovely where you are;
Only to think of you gives light
To my dark heart, within whose
night
Your image, though you bide afar,

Glow like a lake-reflected star.

Dare I crave more than only this:
A thrill of love, a transient smile
To gladden all my world awhile?
No more, alas! Is mortal bliss
Not transient as a lover's kiss?

XVI.

Ah, if you knew how soon and late
My eyes long for a sight of you,
Sometimes in passing by my gate
You'd linger until fall of dew,
If you but knew!

Ah, if you knew how sick and sore
My life flags for the want of you,
Straightway you'd enter at the door
And clasp my hand between your
two,
If you but knew!

Ah, if you knew how lost and lone
I watch and weep and wait for you,
You'd press my heart close to your
own
Till love had healed me through
and through,
If you but knew!

XVII.

Your looks have touched my soul
with bright

Ineffable emotion;
As moonbeams on a stormy night
Illume with transitory light
A seagull on her lonely flight
Across the lonely ocean.

Fluttering from out the gloom and
 roar,
 On fitful wing she flies,
Moon-white above the moon-washed
 shore;
Then, drowned in darkness as before,
She's lost, as I when lit no more
 By your beloved eyes.

XVIII.

Oh, brown Eyes with long black
 lashes,
 Young brown Eyes,
Depths of night from which there
 flashes
 Lightning as of summer skies,
Beautiful brown Eyes!

In your veiled mysterious splendour
 Passion lies
Sleeping, but with sudden tender
 Dreams that fill with vague
 surmise
Beautiful brown Eyes.

All my soul, with yearning shaken,
 Asks in sighs—
Who will see your heart awaken,
 Love's divine sunrise

In those young brown Eyes?

XIX.

Once on a golden day,
In the golden month of May,
I gave my heart away—
 Little birds were singing.

I culled my heart in truth,
Wet with the dews of youth,
For love to take, forsooth—
 Little flowers were springing.

Love sweetly laughed at this,
And between kiss and kiss
Fled with my heart in his:
 Winds warmly blowing.

And with his sun and shower
Love kept my heart in flower,
As in the greenest bower
 Rose richly glowing.

Till, worn at evensong,
Love dropped my heart among
Stones by the way ere long;
 Misprizèd token.

There in the wind and rain,
Trampled and rent in twain,
Ne'er to be whole again,
 My heart lies broken.

XX.

What magic is there in thy mien,
What sorcery in thy smile,
Which charms away all cark and care,
Which turns the foul days into fair,
And for a little while
Changes this disenchanted scene
From the sere leaf into the green,
Transmuting with love's golden
wand
This beggared life to fairyland?

My heart goes forth to thee, oh friend,
As some poor pilgrim to a shrine,
A pilgrim who has come from far
To seek his spirit's folding star,
And sees the taper shine;
The goal to which his wanderings
tend,
Where want and weariness shall end,
And kneels ecstatically blest
Because his heart hath entered rest.

HEART'S-EASE.

As opiates to the sick on wakeful
nights,
As light to flowers, as flowers in
poor men's rooms,
As to the fisher when the tempest
glooms
The cheerful twinkling of his village
lights;
As emerald isles to flagging swallow
flights,

As roses garlanding with tendrilled
 blossoms
The unweeded hillocks of forgotten
 tombs,
As singing birds on cypress-
 shadowed heights,

Thou art to me—a comfort past
 compare—
For thy joy-kindling presence,
 sweet as May
Sets all my nerves to music, makes
 away
With sorrow and the numbing frost of
 care,
Until the influence of thine eyes'
 bright sway
Has made life's glass go up from foul
 to fair.

UNTIMELY LOVE.

Peace, throbbing heart, nor let us
 shed one tear
O'er this late love's unseasonable
 glow;
Sweet as a violet blooming in the
 snow,
The posthumous offspring of the
 widowed year,
That smells of March when all the
 world is sere,
And, while around the hurtling sea-
 winds blow—
Which twist the oak and lay the
 pine tree low—

Stands childlike in the storm and has
no fear.

Poor helpless blossom orphaned of
the sun,
How could it thus brave winter's
rude estate?
Oh love, more helpless love, why
bloom so late,
Now that the flower-time of the year
is done?
Since thy dear course must end when
scarce begun,
Nipped by the cold touch of
untoward fate.

THE AFTER-GLOW.

It is a solemn evening, golden-clear
—
The Alpine summits flame with
rose-lit snow
And headlands purpling on wide
seas below,
And clouds and woods and arid rocks
appear
Dissolving in the sun's own
atmosphere
And vast circumference of light,
whose slow
Transfiguration—glow and after-
glow—
Turns twilight earth to a more
luminous sphere.

Oh heart, I ask, seeing that the orb of
 day
Has sunk below, yet left to sky and
 sea
 His glory's spiritual after-shine:
I ask if Love, whose sun hath set for
 thee,
May not touch grief with his
 memorial ray,
And lend to loss itself a joy divine?

L'ENVOI.

Thou art the goal for which my spirit
 longs;
 As dove on dove,
Bound for one home, I send thee all
 my songs
 With all my love.

Thou art the haven with fair harbour
 lights;
 Safe locked in thee,
My heart would anchor after stormful
 nights
 Alone at sea.

Thou art the rest of which my life is
 fain,
 The perfect peace;
Absorbed in thee the world, with all
 its pain
 And toil, would cease.

Thou art the heaven to which my soul
 would go!

O dearest eyes,
Lost in your light you would turn hell
below
To Paradise.

Thou all in all for which my heart-
blood yearns!
Yea, near or far—
Where the unfathomed ether throbs
and burns
With star on star,

Or where, enkindled by the fires of
June,
The fresh earth glows,
Blushing beneath the mystical white
moon
Through rose on rose—

Thee, thee I see, thee feel in all live
things,
Beloved one;
In the first bird which tremulously
sings
Ere peep of sun;

In the last nestling orphaned in the
hedge,
Rocked to and fro,
When dying summer shudders in the
sedge,
And swallows go;

When roaring snows rush down the
mountain-pass,
March floods with rills,
Or April lightens through the living
grass

In daffodils;

When popped cornfields simmer in
the heat

With tare and thistle,
And, like winged clouds above the
mellow wheat,
The starlings whistle;

When stained with sunset the wide
moorlands glare

In the wild weather,
And clouds with flaming craters
smoke and flare
Red o'er red heather;

When the bent moon, on frostbound
midnights waking,

Leans to the snow
Like some world-mother whose deep
heart is breaking
O'er human woe.

As the round sun rolls red into the
ocean,

Till all the sea
Glowes fluid gold, even so life's mazy
motion
Is dyed with thee:

For as the wave-like years subside
and roll,

O heart's desire,
Thy soul glows interfused within my
soul,
A quenchless fire.

Yea, thee I feel, all storms of life
 above,
 Near though afar;
O thou my glorious morning star of
 love,
 And evening star.

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WORKS BY MATHILDE BLIND.

Poetry.

THE PROPHECY OF SAINT ORAN, and other Poems.
THE HEATHER ON FIRE.

Prose Fiction.

TARANTELLA: A Romance.

Monographs.

GEORGE ELIOT.
MADAME ROLAND.

OPINIONS OF THE PRESS.

THE PROPHECY OF SAINT ORAN,

And other Poems.

"There is perhaps no phase of our history more capable of poetic treatment than the sainted lives of the Irish monks who first spread the Christian faith over the western shores of Scotland, and yet it would be difficult to point to a single representative poem having Saint Columba and the devoted band of his disciples for its heroes. An attempt at filling up this gap has recently been made by Miss Blind in a narrative poem devoted to the fate of St. Oran, the friend and disciple of St. Columba.... Apart from the sonorous beauty of her lines, there is in her diction a straightforwardness and simplicity, and an entire absence of affectation and false sentiment, which, combined with considerable power of characterization, make her volume a remarkable contribution to English literature."—*Times*, September 26, 1881.

"To disturb the *motif* of a legend is always a bold, and mostly a rash, proceeding.... And yet so skilfully is the story handled that the main incidents of the legend do not lose, but gain by this disturbance of the *motif*, and the character of Oran, which with the old *motif* could only have presented the single side of the religious enthusiast, becomes a character exhibiting that complexity which modern taste demands.... Directness of style and lucidity of narrative are the characteristic excellences of the poem. There are few contemporary poets who could have done so much dramatic business in so few lines.... In each of the sonnets there is a thought that is well expressed, and worth expressing."—*Athenæum*, July 30, 1881.

"It is in the domain of character that the poem is distinguished by its highest excellence. There is an ideal statuesqueness embodied in the person of St.

Columba such as is felt to possess a powerful appeal to the imagination. The poem embraces many passions, of which the most tender and beautiful finds expression in the exquisite creation of the radiant golden-haired girl for whose love St. Oran breaks his vow of chastity. But the really powerful contribution to our knowledge of character which this book contains is fittingly centred in St. Oran himself. A dramatic instinct of high order finds utterance in his struggles between opposing passions. Nor are the metrical excellences of the poem less conspicuous.... If one were in need of some single phrase by which to denote the ultimate effect produced by this book, one might say that it seems the most *mature* of all recent first efforts, even of established rank."—*Academy*, July 16, 1881.

"In the choice of a subject for her chief poem she has been singularly fortunate.... That a story such as this is full of poetical suggestiveness is obvious, and Miss Blind has proved herself equal to the occasion. She has avoided writing anything approaching to a 'tendency poem.' She metes out justice with an equal hand to all her characters. The genuine enthusiasm and religious zeal of the monks are set forth in language as inspired as is the final protest of St. Oran against their narrow fanaticism; and one of the best passages in the book is indeed the Sermon in which St. Columba announces the Gospel of love and redemption to the islanders."—*Pall Mall Gazette*, August 22, 1881.

"'The Prophecy of Saint Oran' is skilfully told and vigorously written. In the description of nature and scenery; in the delineation of character; and in the management of singularly difficult positions there is visible a firm and practised hand, a bold and unmistakable power. 'The Street Children's Dance' not unworthily ranks with some of the touching pieces of Hood, Mrs. Barrett Browning, and others."—*British Mail*, September 1, 1881.

"The only excuse for street music that can reasonably be considered valid is the touching plea for public toleration which is embodied in Miss Mathilde Blind's poem, wherein the spectacle of poor children dancing round an

organ is as pathetically moralized and as tender and full of loving pity as Mrs. Browning's 'Cry of the Children.'"—*Daily Telegraph*, September 1, 1881.

"The poem is rich in true description of sea and sky and mountain, and glows in sympathy with the deeper feelings which stir humanity. There has been published no poem of such creative suggestiveness as this for many a day, and we hope and believe that it is the precursor of other work by the same unfaltering hand. This poem is a true work of art, complete and beautiful. There is in the volume other work which shows a master's touch...."—*Manchester Examiner and Times*, July 1, 1882.

"Il y a là bien plus qu'une simple facilité de versification. Le récit du poème d'ouverture est grand et fort, la manière de raconter est pleine de poésie et d'effet. Depuis la mort de Mrs. Barrett Browning, nous n'avons point eu de poésie aussi hautement inspirée qui ait jailli d'une source féminine."—*Le Livre*, Paris, October 10, 1881.

THE HEATHER ON FIRE:

A Tale of the Highland Clearances.

"Miss Blind has produced one of the most noticeable and moving poems which recent years have added to our shelves.... As a singer with a message her attempt is praiseworthy, and her performance is fairly self-consistent. It is eminently homogeneous; the passion once felt, the inspiration once obeyed, the well-head pours forth its stream in a strong and uniform current, which knows no pause until its impulse ceases.... The story is pathetic at once in its simplicity and in its terror.... We congratulate the author upon her boldness in choosing a subject of our own time, fertile in what is pathetic, and free from any taint of the vulgar and conventional. Poetry of late years has tended too much towards motives of a merely fanciful and abstruse, sometimes a plainly artificial, character; and we have

had much of lyrical energy or attraction, with little of the real marrow of human life, the flesh and blood of man and woman. Positive subject-matter, the emotion which inheres in actual life, the very smile and the very tear and heart-pang, are, after all, precious to poetry, and we have them here. 'The Heather on Fire' may possibly prove to be something of a new departure, and one that was certainly not superfluous."—*Athenæum*, July 17, 1886.

"Miss Blind has chosen for her new poem one of those terrible Highland clearances which stain the history of Scotch landlordism. Though her tale is a fiction it is too well founded on fact.... It may be said generally of the poem that the most difficult scenes are those in which Miss Blind succeeds best; and on the whole we are inclined to think that its greatest and most surprising success is the picture of the poor old soldier Rory driven mad by the burning of his wife. In his frenzy he mixes up his old battles with the French and the descent of the landlord's ejectors upon the village."—*Academy*, August 7, 1886.

"In this versified tale of Highland clearances, Mathilde Blind has, with genuine poetic instinct, selected a family the fortunes of which form the burden of her story.... Literature and poetry are never seen at their best save in contact with actual life.... This little book abounds in vivid delineation of character, and is redolent with the noblest human sympathy."—*Newcastle Daily Chronicle*, June 3, 1886.

"A subject which has painfully preoccupied public opinion is, in the poem entitled 'The Heather on Fire,' treated with characteristic power by Miss Mathilde Blind. Irish evictions have offered so convenient a theme to party strife, that the sufferings of the unhappy Highland crofters have not always met with the compassion they were so well calculated to inspire. In eloquent and forcible verse, Miss Blind tells the tale of their wrongs, their resistance to the hard fate imposed upon them, and describes the bitter grief with which

'Crowding on the decks with hungry
eyes,
Straining towards the coast that flies
and flies,'

those among them driven into exile look on the shores to which many bid an eternal farewell. Both as a narrative and descriptive poem 'The Heather on Fire' is equally remarkable."—*Morning Post*, July 30, 1886.

"We are happy in being able to extend to the present poem a welcome equally sincere and equally hearty; for it is a poem that is rich not only in power and beauty but in that 'enthusiasm of humanity' which stirs and moves us, and of which so much contemporary verse is almost painfully deficient. Miss Blind does not possess her theme; she is possessed by it, as was Mrs. Browning when she wrote 'Aurora Leigh.'... We can best describe the kind of her success by noting the fact that while engaged in the perusal of her book we do not say, 'What a fine poem!' but 'What a terrible story!' or, more probably still, say nothing at all, but read on and on under the spell of a great horror and an over-powering pity. Poetry of which this can be said needs no other recommendation, and, therefore, we need not unduly lengthen our review of 'The Heather on Fire.'"—*Manchester Examiner and Times*, September 1, 1886.

"There are charming pictures of West Highland scenery, in Arran apparently, and of the surroundings and conditions of Highland cottar life."—*Scotsman*, July 20, 1886.

"In 'The Heather on Fire' she exhibits a clearness and beauty of diction, a rhythmical correctness, a grace and simplicity of style which mark her out as no slavish follower of any poetic 'school,' but an unaffected and truthful expression of her own feelings.... Whatever the reader's opinion may be on the grievance which Miss Blind throws into such fierce light, he cannot fail

to be pleased with her graceful tale, so gracefully and simply told."—*Glasgow Herald*, July 20, 1886.

"Miss Mathilde Blind's poem is the tragic epic of the old evictions in the Highlands of Scotland. It is a strange fact that the general reader knows more about the siege of Troy, the Norman Conquest, and the Wars of the Roses, than about such matters in the very history of our own days as the depopulation of the Highlands of Scotland by the landlords. The old story comes to the front just now by reason of the crofter agitation. In the preface to her fine and touching epic, and in the notes at the end, Miss Blind passes in review some of the facts of the eviction of the Glen Sannox people by the Duke of Hamilton in 1832, where, as she says, 'the progress of civilization, which has redeemed many a wilderness and gladdened the solitary places of the world, has come with a curse to these Highland glens, and turned green pastures and golden harvest fields once more into a desert.' The 'Heather on Fire' is a poem in four cantos—or 'Duans'—comprising about two hundred stanzas."—*School Board Chronicle*, July 10, 1886.

"It is written in a strain which must of necessity appeal to the sympathies of all grades of society, and at the same time it is eminently poetical, both in thought and rhythm."—*Western Antiquary*, August, 1886.

"A book like this forms an admirable corrective to the harsh and cold-blooded theories of such landlords as the Duke of Argyle on the rights of his class."—*Cambridge Independent Press*, August, 1886.

"There is a sonorous beauty, a classic dignity and depth of pathos throughout her four cantos, and a vivid and thrilling description is given of the industrious hamlets, the contented happy people, and the ruthless manner in which the evictions were effected by the stewards and ground-officers."—*Elgin Courant*, August, 1886.

TARANTELLA:

A Romance.

"The author of this two-volumed romance is favourably known by other works, and by her appreciative 'Life of George Eliot.' The strange effects of the bite of a tarantula spider, so firmly believed in by the Italian peasantry, and the marvellous power of musical enthusiasm, supply the motive of the story; and the characters are portrayed with great force, pathos, and a touch of homely humour."—*Bookseller*, Christmas, 1884.

"Miss Blind may be congratulated on 'Tarantella,' her first novel. In the *récit* (as we have called it) of the musician, Emanuel Sturm, nearly all the interest of the book is concentrated. The violinist, poor and unknown, finds himself at Capri. Accident brings him, one evening, to a frightened group of women, one of whom has just been bitten by the tarantula, and, according to the popular superstition, he is implored to play, in order to drive the poison out of her. He refuses at first, but afterwards consents, and, finding himself almost supernaturally inspired, plays an improvised 'Tarantella' throughout a whole stormy night, finally curing the girl. The tune thus strangely hit on spreads, and ultimately makes him famous, but the love he has conceived for his Antonella brings him almost as much misery as his music brings him fame."—*Pall Mall Gazette*, February 5, 1885.

"Admiration of the delicate sketching now in vogue should not blind us to the very opposite kind of charm of which 'Tarantella' is full. Entirely poetical in conception (save that it is not written in metre), 'Tarantella' is more essentially a poem than many a narrative written in smooth and elegant verse.... 'Tarantella' is indeed full of strange originality and scenic effects of uncommon powers. The dance among the ruins is not likely to be soon forgotten by the most unimaginative of readers, and it is rarely, we think, that in an English novel the psychology of the poetic temperament

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